

REVIEW PAPER

Key Drivers Underpinning the Donation Behavior: A Systematic Literature Review and Agenda for Future Research Using the TCCM Framework

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Received: 26 May 2025 | **Revised:** 18 November 2025 | **Accepted:** 3 December 2025

Keywords: donation behavior | donation motivation | framework-based review | systematic literature review | TCCM framework

ABSTRACT

Donation, whether through money, materials, or time, has long been vital to the sustainability of nonprofit organizations and the cohesion of societies. Thus, understanding the key drivers behind donation behavior is a critical concern across multiple disciplines, yet the existing literature remains fragmented and theoretically diverse. This study employs a systematic literature review (SLR) guided by the TCCM (Theory–Context–Characteristics–Methods) framework to synthesize and evaluate the academic landscape on donation motivation. Drawing on a comprehensive analysis of 116 peer-reviewed publications from 1993 to 2025, the review identifies the dominant theoretical foundations, including self-determination theory, the theory of planned behavior, social exchange theory, the theory of prosocial behavior, and signaling theory, while also highlighting conceptual gaps and emerging paradigms. Contextually, the study maps research across diverse geographical, cultural, and technological settings, with a particular focus on the transformative role of digital platforms and global crises in shaping donor engagement. In terms of characteristics, it categorizes key motivational drivers into intrinsic and extrinsic categories, encompassing empathy, social recognition, relief of suffering, and the warm-glow giving. Methodologically, the review reveals a predominance of quantitative approaches, with limited integration of mixed-methods and longitudinal designs. By systematically organizing insights through the TCCM lens, this review not only clarifies the current state of research but also provides actionable recommendations for scholars, practitioners, and policymakers seeking to deepen their engagement with diverse donor segments in an evolving philanthropic landscape.

1 | Introduction

Human societies have long been shaped by acts of giving, with donations playing a pivotal role in sustaining nonprofit organizations, funding public goods, and promoting social cohesion (Sargeant and Woodliffe 2007a, 2007b; Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). This historical continuity highlights that philanthropy is not just a cultural activity but also an established system through which societies uphold social welfare and collective well-being. For example, in 2024, total charitable contributions in the United States reached \$592.50 billion,

with \$392.45 billion (67%) coming from individual donors, \$44.40 billion from corporate philanthropy, and \$109.81 billion from foundations. In the same year, approximately 75.7 million Americans volunteered a total of 4.99 billion hours, which equates to a labor value of about \$167.2 billion (National Philanthropic Trust 2024). Globally, charitable giving reached an estimated \$1.1 trillion in 2023, with North America, Europe, and Asia-Pacific collectively making up over 85% of this figure. The United States continued to be the largest single donor market, followed by China, Germany, and the United Kingdom. Participation rates in charitable activities also surpassed 60%

in countries like Indonesia, Kenya, and Myanmar, highlighting the strength of community-based giving traditions (Charities Aid Foundation 2024; OECD 2024). These numbers collectively demonstrate the importance of philanthropy not just as a way to promote social solidarity but also as a significant contributor to economic value. As a result, donation behavior is increasingly viewed not only as an act of generosity but as a complex phenomenon rooted in economic, cultural, and psychological systems.

The motivations behind donations, whether monetary, material, or time-based, have attracted considerable interest across various disciplines, including psychology, sociology, economics, marketing, and nonprofit management (Andreoni 2006; Wiepking and Bekkers 2012; Breeze and Lives 2013). This scholarly attention reflects the understanding that charitable giving goes beyond individual moral choices to include broader institutional dynamics and policy implications. Gaining a deeper understanding of why individuals and institutions participate in philanthropic activities is therefore crucial for a wide range of stakeholders, from academic researchers and policymakers to nonprofit leaders and fundraisers (Sargeant and Shang 2010). In this context, studying donation behavior serves as a key link between theory and practice, guiding strategies that improve fundraising success and boost civic engagement. Drivers for engaging in donation behavior are inherently complex and multifaceted, shaped by an interplay of internal psychological states and external social influences (Batson et al. 1991; Clary et al. 1998). Intrinsic factors such as empathy, altruism, and moral obligation often drive individuals to support causes that align with their personal values or emotional concerns (Batson and Shaw 1991; Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). Conversely, extrinsic motivators such as social recognition, tax incentives, or perceived personal benefits (e.g., improved reputation or networking opportunities) can also significantly influence donor behavior (Andreoni 1990; Glazer and Konrad 2008; Harbaugh 1998). Additionally, demographic variables, such as age, income level, education, and religious affiliation, can further modulate the nature and extent of donation behaviors (Wiepking and Maas 2009; Philpot et al. 2016). Beyond these individual-level determinants, social norms and peer influences play a pivotal role by mediating the relationship between intrinsic and extrinsic motivations. Social norms and peer influences, on the other hand, serve as a bridge between intrinsic and extrinsic motivations. While normative norms emerge as an external influence, they shape individuals' internal moral responsibilities, as exemplified by their role in shaping moral responsibility (White et al. 2023). This bridging mechanism can bring together intrinsic and extrinsic factors by strengthening empathy through one's geographical and psychological proximity to the issue or person in need (Hellmann et al. 2021). A recent meta-analysis focusing on the theory of planned behavior shows that subjective and moral norms, attitudes, and perceived behavioral control largely explain differences in donation intentions (White et al. 2023). Taken together, these findings highlight that motivational categories should not be understood as mutually exclusive, but rather as interacting and dynamically reinforcing each other within specific social contexts. These findings suggest that intrinsic and extrinsic motivations are not independent concepts but rather interact. Such interactions are particularly salient in contemporary

donation environments, where social influence mechanisms are amplified through digital platforms and transnational advocacy networks.

People tend to donate more when they believe others in their network are also donating, particularly in tightly knit communities or online spaces where giving behavior is visible (Shang and Croson 2009a, 2009b; Croson and Shang 2013). Similarly, cause of proximity, how closely a donor identifies with the people or issues involved, amplifies the likelihood and magnitude of giving (Small and Simonsohn 2008). This demonstrates that the spatial, relational, and emotional closeness of donors to beneficiaries critically conditions prosocial decisions. Recent studies have shown that native identity and perceived closeness significantly increase altruistic giving to refugees, whereas student identity sharing or perceived income differences do not produce the expected effects (Hellmann et al. 2021). These results suggest that the concept of "closeness" has physical, social, and psychological dimensions, and that interactions between ideological orientation and prosocial tendencies shape donation behavior. Consequently, donor decisions are not only products of rational cost-benefit calculations but also embedded in identity-related processes that shape solidaristic bonds across communities. Donors are also influenced by the perceived effectiveness of nonprofit organizations, with trust, transparency, and measurable outcomes being key determinants of support (Sargeant and Lee 2004; Bennett and Barkensjo 2005). In parallel, organizational accountability and demonstrable impact have become central benchmarks for donors who seek assurance that their contributions generate tangible social outcomes.

In recent decades, the advent of digital platforms and global crises (e.g., climate change, pandemics, refugee emergencies) has transformed the landscape of philanthropy, introducing new forms of giving such as crowdfunding, peer-to-peer fundraising, and social media-driven donations (Saxton and Wang 2014; Burtch et al. 2013; Kshetri et al. 2020). These emerging channels have prompted renewed interest in understanding what motivates donors in an increasingly digital and interconnected world (Shier and Handy 2012). The immediacy and emotional storytelling of digital campaigns, combined with mobile payment technology and gamification, have dramatically reshaped donor engagement, especially among younger, tech-savvy populations (Gomez et al. 2020). Moreover, cultural and contextual differences across regions add another layer of complexity, requiring context-sensitive approaches to donor engagement (Hofstede 2001; Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). Beyond technological shifts, structural disruptions such as global crises have also redefined philanthropic patterns in profound ways. Global crises have also fundamentally altered giving patterns. A study conducted in Germany and Austria during the COVID-19 pandemic showed that individuals affected mentally, financially, or health-wise by the pandemic were more likely to change their giving behavior. While the pandemic led many donors experiencing economic insecurity to withdraw, it also spurred community-focused fundraising campaigns and spontaneous prosocial behavior (Litofcenko et al. 2023). Climate philanthropy has similarly increased; climate finance grew by 20% in 2023, directing \$9.3–15.8 billion to climate change mitigation (ClimateWorks Foundation 2024). These trends demonstrate that crises such as pandemics, refugee emergencies, and climate

disasters can both trigger and hinder philanthropic participation, thus highlighting the importance of contextual factors in understanding giving motivations. Taken together, these developments reveal that donor behavior is not static but evolves in response to systemic shocks, digital innovation, and shifting cultural expectations.

Despite the abundance of studies exploring various aspects of donation behavior, the existing literature remains fragmented, with findings dispersed across disciplines and often employing differing theoretical frameworks, methodologies, and focal points (Wiepking and Bekkers 2012; Breeze and Lives 2013). Some studies emphasize economic models of rational choice and utility maximization, while others adopt psychological or sociological lenses that prioritize identity, emotion, or social norms (Andreoni 1989; Clary et al. 1998; Sargeant et al. 2006). Moreover, while substantial research has been conducted on individual-level motivations, less attention has been given to institutional donors or cross-sector partnerships in philanthropy (Ma and Konrath 2018). Even systematic attempts to consolidate insights often mirror this disciplinary fragmentation, and recent reviews highlight this fragmentation. For example, a 2023 meta-analysis of theory-planned behavior synthesized only the constructs of this model across 117 samples, excluding other theoretical frameworks (White et al. 2023). This selective focus illustrates how narrow theoretical lenses can limit generalizability and obscure the broader determinants of giving behavior. This fragmentation makes it challenging to draw comprehensive conclusions about the state of knowledge in the field and limits the ability to identify gaps, trends, and opportunities for future research (Tranfield et al. 2003). Given this conceptual and methodological diversity, a systematic literature review (SLR) emerges as an appropriate and necessary approach to synthesize fragmented findings, map the evolution of theoretical perspectives, and uncover underexplored areas of inquiry. Although donation behavior has been studied across multiple disciplines such as psychology, sociology, and economics, the present review deliberately focuses on the Business and Management domain. This disciplinary boundary was defined to ensure analytical coherence and methodological comparability across studies, given the diversity of theoretical and empirical approaches found in broader philanthropic research. Business and Management journals often integrate interdisciplinary constructs, drawing on psychological, sociological, and economic perspectives, while maintaining a focus on decision-making, organizational behavior, and marketing implications. Thus, while this review acknowledges that its findings are not fully generalizable to all disciplinary contexts, its scope enables a systematic and domain-specific synthesis of how donation motivation has been conceptualized and empirically examined within Business and Management research. This focus provides a rigorous yet bounded understanding of the field, paving the way for future comparative reviews that can extend across additional disciplinary domains. While this focus may appear to reproduce a disciplinary boundary, the purpose of the review is not to claim universality but to reduce internal fragmentation within the Business and Management literature itself. By offering a coherent and cumulative synthesis in this domain, the study establishes a solid empirical and theoretical foundation for future interdisciplinary integrations that can address broader fragmentation across fields.

Accordingly, the current study addresses the following questions:

RQ1. What are the dominant theories, contexts, characteristics, and methodological approaches (TCCM) in the existing literature on donation motivation, and how do these dimensions interact with each other?

RQ2. How are theories, contexts, characteristics, and methodological approaches combined in current studies on donation motivation, and what dominant or underdeveloped patterns can be identified among these combinations?

RQ3. What are the underexplored areas and avenues for future research concerning the theories, contexts, characteristics, and methods?

This systematic literature review (SLR) offers several critical benefits. First, it provides a rigorous and transparent framework for synthesizing a fragmented body of knowledge on donation motivation, encompassing a diverse range of intrinsic drivers (e.g., empathy, altruism, moral obligation) and extrinsic drivers (e.g., social recognition, tax incentives, peer influence). By classifying and evaluating these motivational dimensions within a coherent analytical structure, it strengthens the reliability and generalizability of the insights drawn (Moher et al. 2009). Second, such a review facilitates the temporal and theoretical cultivation of the field within the Business and Management literature, illustrating how core concepts, such as social norms or cause proximity, have been interpreted, often through the integration of psychological, sociological, and economic perspectives, as reflected in this domain. This helps distinguish whether such constructs operate as external cues or are internalized as part of individuals' value systems, thus clarifying theoretical ambiguities (Denyer and Tranfield 2009). Third, by systematically identifying the strategies most commonly associated with specific motivational profiles, this review delivers practical implications for nonprofit managers aiming to tailor donor engagement efforts, for example, by aligning messaging with emotionally driven or normatively guided motivations (Sargeant and Shang 2010). Finally, the review informs future research agendas by surfacing inconsistencies in theoretical applications, highlighting underrepresented populations or contexts, and revealing methodological gaps such as the overreliance on cross-sectional survey designs or limited integration of qualitative insights (Petticrew and Roberts 2008).

What distinguishes this SLR from prior efforts is its systematic integration of the TCCM framework, which enables a multi-dimensional mapping of the field. Unlike earlier narrative reviews that tended to emphasize descriptive insights without methodological transparency, this study reduces bias and enhances reproducibility by adhering to a structured protocol. Moreover, it advances theoretical integration by explicitly connecting established frameworks, such as Signaling Theory, Self-Determination Theory, Norm Activation Theory, and the Theory of Planned Behavior, into a holistic conceptualization of donation behavior. By doing so, it moves beyond one-dimensional explanations and demonstrates how donations operate simultaneously as altruistic acts, strategic signals, and normatively guided behaviors. In addition, this review contributes a long-term perspective by classifying research trends over the past

three decades, thereby capturing the intellectual evolution of the field. It highlights the predominance of Western-centric evidence and the methodological bias toward quantitative approaches, drawing attention to the need for geographical diversification and greater reliance on qualitative and mixed-method designs. These additions not only broaden contextual understanding but also enhance the robustness of theoretical generalizations. In doing so, it not only consolidates existing knowledge but also provides a targeted roadmap for advancing research on the psychological, social, and contextual antecedents of donation behavior.

2 | Method

2.1 | Systematic Review

A systematic review is a form of secondary research that applies transparent and reproducible procedures to identify, evaluate, and synthesize existing studies around a specific research question (Paul and Criado 2020). Its purpose is to provide an updated and comprehensive understanding of the literature, highlight inconsistencies or gaps, and propose structured directions for future research (Sauer and Seuring 2023; Kocaman and Coşgun 2024). Systematic reviews can take several forms, including meta-analytical, theory-based, method-based, and domain-based (Paul and Criado 2020). The present study adopts a domain-based systematic review with a framework-based approach. This design is particularly suitable for mapping what is known about donation behavior, clarifying how this knowledge has been generated, and identifying where future research should focus. By employing the TCCM framework (Theory–Context–Characteristics–Methods), the review integrates prior findings in a coherent and structured way, supports theoretical advancement, and reveals opportunities for methodological and contextual diversification (Paul and Benito 2018; Donthu et al. 2020).

2.2 | Organizing the Framework

The content should be systematically organized to ensure the rigor, relevance, and impact of a systematic review. This method sets the review apart from typical reviews by effectively structuring information (Siddaway et al. 2019). Such an arrangement allows readers to quickly locate specific details and understand where to find pertinent information (Paul and Criado 2020; Paul and Menzies 2023). To thoroughly organize the key aspects of previous research, this review adopts the TCCM framework from the various options available for developing systematic reviews. Theories represent researchers' guiding perspectives, contexts involve the situations under examination, characteristics indicate the components of a construct and their interplay with other variables related to the relevant research topic, while methods outline the empirical evidence used. The TCCM framework helps in systematically synthesizing theories, methodologies, geographical and sectoral contexts, and characteristics of the extant literature (Billore and Anisimova 2021; Basu et al. 2022; Chakma et al. 2021; D'Alessandro et al. 2023; De Keyser and Kunz 2022; Hassan et al. 2022; Khlystova et al. 2022; Roy Bhattacharjee et al. 2022). This framework enhances the

replicability of research by offering a structured approach to organize and synthesize literature across four key dimensions: theory, context, characteristics, and methods (Paul and Rosado-Serrano 2019). This systematic method enables researchers to document their review process in a way that others can easily replicate, allowing future scholars to understand the logic and criteria used in study selection, coding, and analysis (Paul, Lim, et al. 2021). Furthermore, the framework supports knowledge development by identifying gaps related to theory, context, characteristics, and methods, thus helping to create targeted research agendas and refine conceptual frameworks (Paul and Criado 2020). In this way, the framework integrates scattered knowledge, fosters cumulative theoretical growth, and encourages a broader range of inquiry in the field. Reviews based on TCCM are more effective than other frameworks in establishing a solid future research agenda, which is crucial for systematic review articles (Celik et al. 2022).

2.3 | Procedure

Establishing a reporting protocol is crucial to the systematic review process. This step boosts the study's integrity and transparency by ensuring thorough planning and documentation of the methodology. In this study, the PRISMA (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses) protocol, which serves as the benchmark for systematic review reporting, informed the selection of articles examining the key drivers of donation behavior. The protocol provides a systematic and transparent framework that improves the rigor, reproducibility, and clarity of systematic reviews. By guiding researchers through well-defined steps, from selecting studies to synthesizing data, it reduces bias and guarantees methodological consistency. Its checklist and flow diagram support comprehensive reporting while promoting the critical evaluation of the studies included (Kocaman et al. 2025). The protocol's recent and extensive application highlights the robustness of its framework (e.g., Pushparaj and Kushwaha 2024; Zheng et al. 2024; Ganti and Singhania 2025). It consists of four key stages: identification, screening, eligibility, and inclusion. It provides a systematic framework for the review process to apply the inclusion criteria given below:

- Publication type—Peer-reviewed journal articles to ensure scholarly rigor and quality control through expert review.
- Language—Published in English, as it is the predominant language of academic communication and ensures consistency in interpretation.
- Research fields—Belonged to the Business and Management fields (including marketing and nonprofit management)
- Topical relevance—Explicitly investigated determinants, drivers, or influencing factors of donation behavior in any form (e.g., charitable giving, philanthropy, and prosocial donations).
- Theoretical or empirical contribution—Presented original empirical data or made a substantive theoretical contribution to understanding key drivers of donation behavior. In this study, substantive theoretical contribution refers to conceptual or theoretical papers that (a) propose a new

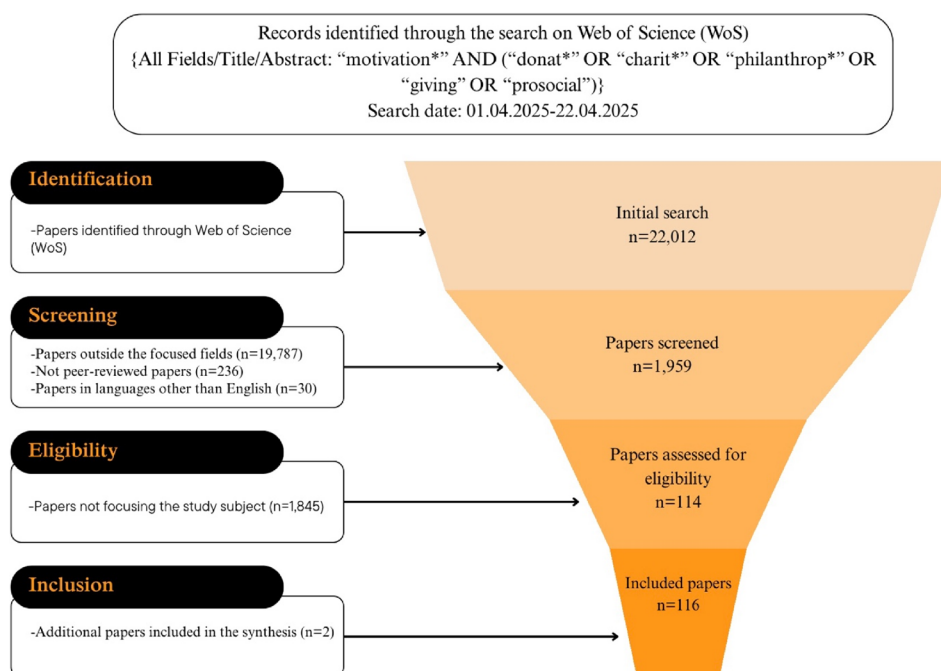


FIGURE 1 | Article selection process employing the PRISMA Protocol.

framework, model, or conceptualization to explain donation behavior, (b) extend or integrate existing theories into the donation context, or (c) offer novel theoretical propositions or relationships that advance understanding of underlying mechanisms. Such studies were included if their theoretical insights were explicitly developed and supported by logical argumentation, literature synthesis, or conceptual modeling.

Figure 1 depicts these stages, which are further explained in the following sections, drawing on the insights of ter Huurne et al. (2017).

2.3.1 | Identification

The identification stage utilized five criteria for categorization: search keywords, source quality, and search period. The keywords ("motivation*" AND ("donat*" OR "charit*" OR "philanthrop*" OR "giving" OR "prosocial")) for the database search were carefully selected to ensure comprehensiveness, focusing on the key drivers of donation behavior. The search strategy was designed to ensure both comprehensiveness and precision. Specifically, the search string was applied to the titles, abstracts, and keywords of articles indexed in the Web of Science (WoS) database, rather than to the full texts. This approach follows established practices in systematic literature reviews, as titles, abstracts, and keywords typically capture the central focus of the study and provide sufficient information for determining relevance (Sauer and Seuring 2023). Applying the string in this way helped minimize the inclusion of irrelevant matches while still ensuring that key contributions across the domain were identified. The dataset was compiled using the WoS to guarantee the quality of sources. Although many databases like Scopus, EBSCO, and Google Scholar are available,

five reasons justified the selection of WoS: (1) it is the most extensive source of citation data globally (Birkle et al. 2020); (2) it offers a broad range of English-language publications since 1990 (Öztürk and Dil 2022); (3) it may be more effective in searching and analyzing open access publications at the publication level (Pranckutė 2021); (4) it covers a variety of knowledge domains (Li et al. 2018); and (5) it grants institutional members access to these publications (Öztürk et al. 2024). Furthermore, WoS indexes high-impact, peer-reviewed journals, thereby ensuring that systematic review literature maintains high scholarly standards and minimizing the chances of incorporating low-quality or predatory articles that may skew results. Its carefully curated list contributes to a uniform level of scholarly rigor, which is essential in systematic reviews. If the topic is narrowly focused and WoS includes the primary journals in that field, researchers may find it justifiable to restrict their search to this database. A targeted review may not yield significant value from additional sources if the relevant database already has a strong representation. This position is supported by evidence from scientometric research showing that WoS performs robustly in capturing core, high-impact literature. For example, Archambault et al. (2009) reported extremely high correlations ($R^2 > 0.99$) between WoS and Scopus in country-level bibliometric indicators, while Visser et al. (2021) found strong document and citation coverage overlap between WoS and other major databases such as Scopus, Dimensions, and Crossref. Similarly, Martín-Martín et al. (2018) demonstrated that 95% of citations indexed in WoS are also found in Google Scholar, indicating that WoS captures the majority of influential works in the academic record. These findings suggest that, when the subject area is well represented in WoS, as is the case here for Business and Management journals publishing research from such perspectives as marketing, psychology, sociology, and economics, relying on WoS, supplemented with validation strategies such as citation chaining and manual journal scanning, can provide a comprehensive and

methodologically sound evidence base for a systematic review. In addition to these, WoS provides notable advantages in citation indexing and impact tracking, owing to its innovative citation analysis tools. It was the pioneer in citation indexing and offers well-established metrics like the Journal Impact Factor (JIF), which are widely recognized for evaluations and assessments. While other databases, like Scopus, provide newer metrics such as CiteScore, SNIP, and SJR, these are not as universally accepted. For researchers in need of comprehensive, long-term citation data and reliable impact metrics, WoS continues to be the preferred choice. Lastly, WoS features a user-friendly interface, advanced search functionalities, and export tools compatible with EndNote, Zotero, and Mendeley, which help minimize errors in data collection and reference management. The search conducted from April 01, 2025, to April 22, 2025, focused on articles published between 1993 and 2025. The starting point of 1993 was not predetermined but emerged after the eligibility assessment, as this was the earliest year in which relevant studies appeared in the dataset. While we acknowledge that including studies from more than three decades introduces a degree of heterogeneity in theoretical frameworks, societal contexts, and methodological approaches, this temporal breadth also provides valuable insights into the evolution of the field. This stage revealed a total of 22,012 articles.

2.3.2 | Screening

This review limited the study fields to Business and Management, as the study's primary objective was to synthesize insights most relevant to marketing, nonprofit management, and organizational strategy, while also capturing interdisciplinary perspectives from psychology, sociology, and economics that are frequently published in leading Business and Management journals. Consequently, we excluded 19,787 papers from other fields of study in the review process. This boundary means that our findings should be understood as representing the state of research within the relevant fields and closely related interdisciplinary outlets, rather than the entirety of global scholarship on donation behavior. Additionally, the review focused solely on journal articles, intentionally excluding 236 non-journal papers such as book chapters, theses, technical notes, and conference papers. Although contributions in books and edited volumes can be valuable, their peer-review processes are typically less standardized and vary widely across publishers and editorial practices (Greenhalgh et al. 2018). In contrast, journal articles undergo a rigorous and systematic peer-review process that ensures greater methodological transparency, comparability, and consistency across studies (Podsakoff et al. 2005). Moreover, journal articles are more comprehensively indexed in leading citation databases such as WoS, facilitating reproducibility and enabling reliable bibliometric analysis (Snyder 2019). For these reasons, we restricted our dataset to journal articles, as this decision guarantees a consistent quality threshold and strengthens the reliability and credibility of the systematic review. Lastly, it is generally recommended to concentrate on literature published in English as it is the language of science (Paul and Criado 2020). Thus, 30 articles that were written in languages other than English were excluded. This comprehensive screening procedure yielded 1959 articles for eligibility evaluation.

2.3.3 | Eligibility

Researchers need to manually examine the previews (i.e., title, abstract, and keywords) of articles that remain after automated filtering to remove those that are irrelevant due to inaccurate matches (Sauer and Seuring 2023). Therefore, during the eligibility stage, we conducted a detailed manual review of 1959 full-text articles, focusing on those that contribute original insights and excluding studies that merely replicate previous findings. In addition to this relevance screening, we performed a quality assessment of the eligible studies. Each article was evaluated on criteria such as the clarity of research questions, appropriateness of study design, transparency of data collection, rigor of analysis, and validity of reported findings. Studies that failed to meet these minimum quality standards were excluded to ensure the robustness of the evidence base. Thus, 1845 articles were excluded from the review due to their lack of direct relevance to the study topic, conceptual or methodological duplication, limited empirical support, or inadequate methodological rigor. This comprehensive eligibility evaluation resulted in a refined set of 114 articles that align with the study's emphasis on the key drivers underpinning donation behavior.

2.3.4 | Inclusion

The list of articles was carefully counter-checked during the inclusion stage to confirm its completeness and validity. Accordingly, the authors rechecked the data set to determine the relevance of each study to the study topic, assess its theoretical foundations, evaluate the adequacy of its research methodologies, and examine the reliability of its data. This rigorous process served as a quality control measure, designed to detect and correct any potential errors or omissions in the selection process. After evaluating and discussing their relevance and adequacy, two previously overlooked articles were added, resulting in a total of 118 articles selected for synthesis in the review. The following sections delve into the findings of the thorough content analysis.

3 | General Overview

This section provides a detailed overview of the articles selected for the systematic review. First, publication trends are analyzed based on the years the selected studies were published. Next, details about the most productive publication outlets are given. Lastly, the most prolific articles are presented, highlighting their authors, publication year, citation per year, and total citations.

3.1 | Publication Trends

This review covers the articles published between 1993 and 2025. An examination of the yearly distribution of studies reveals a notable rise in academic interest in this subject, particularly in recent years. Although the first research emerged in 1993, indicating that it has been present in the literature for quite some time, it initially comprised only a few studies. The occurrence of one or two publications annually during the 1990s and 2000s suggests that this subject had not yet garnered significant attention from

researchers in that era. These early studies were primarily descriptive, focusing on socio-demographic predictors such as income, education, and age, and often employed survey-based methods reflecting the economic and sociological frameworks of the time. After 2010, there was an observable upward trend in publications focused on donation motivation, with a notable increase in the number of annual publications, particularly since 2015. During this period, research increasingly incorporated psychological perspectives such as trust, identity, and moral reasoning, alongside more diverse methodological approaches, including experiments and cross-cultural comparisons. Since the 2010s, and especially in the post-digital era, donation behavior research has turned toward the impact of online and mobile donations, crowdfunding, and the influence of digital platforms and social media. More recently, the 2020s have emphasized crisis-driven and context-specific giving, such as pandemic-related donations and disaster relief, supported by methodological advances including longitudinal studies and big data analytics. This growth appears to have accelerated from 2020 onward. The heightened interest in phenomena such as social solidarity, individual helping behaviors, and social responsibility, triggered by the pandemic, may have also contributed to academic productivity in this area. In fact, 2021 marked the year with the most intense activity, culminating in a total of 18 publications. This number decreased to 12 in 2022 and 11 in 2024. Additionally, it is significant that the number of publications in both 2019 and 2020 was high, each reaching 9 publications. In 2025, only one publication was identified; however, this low number can be attributed to the timing of data collection, which ended on April 24, 2025, early in the second quarter of the year. Therefore, it is likely that the number of publications for 2025 will increase over the remainder of the year.

Recent data indicate that the study subject has become an increasingly focal point for researchers in both theoretical and practical realms. Taken together, the chronological trajectory highlights how donation behavior research has evolved from socio-demographic baselines in the 1990s, to psychologically informed models in the 2000s, and finally to digitally mediated and crisis-responsive frameworks in the 2010s and 2020s. This heightened interest can be attributed to the subject's connection with current social trends, its role in understanding individual behaviors, and its potential to engage with different disciplines. It is anticipated that this trend will persist in the coming years, leading to an increase in extensive, cross-cultural, and contextual studies on the drivers of donation behavior.

3.2 | Publication Outlets

Reviewed studies are primarily published in a limited number of journals. The *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing* is the foremost outlet, with 11 studies on the subject. It is closely followed by the *Journal of Nonprofit Public Sector Marketing*, which has published 10 articles. Both journals emphasize the importance of nonprofit and public interest topics in the donation motivation literature. Furthermore, the *International Review on Public and Nonprofit Marketing and Psychology & Marketing* have each released six studies, showcasing the interdisciplinary connections between nonprofit management and consumer psychology. Other significant journals include the *Journal of Business Ethics* and the *Journal of*

Consumer Behaviour, each with five studies, in addition to several others like the *Journal of Business Research*, *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, *Journal of Islamic Marketing*, *Journal of Philanthropy and Marketing*, and *Nonprofit Management & Leadership*, all of which have contributed four studies (Table 1).

This distribution indicates the increasing scholarly focus on the psychological, ethical, and managerial aspects of donation behavior in both nonprofit and marketing-oriented publications.

3.3 | Most Prolific Articles

A review of the most frequently cited studies shows significant variations in total citations and average annual citations (Table 2). The top-cited article is by Du (2015), which examines whether corporate philanthropy serves as a facade for environmental wrongdoing in Chinese family-owned businesses. This study has garnered 187 total citations, averaging 20.77 citations per year, which reflects its substantial influence in the discipline. Following closely is the research by Bagheri et al. (2019), which analyzes donor motivations within the field of crowdfunding. Despite being published relatively recently, this article has already garnered 126 citations and boasts the highest annual citation rate (25.20) among the listed studies. Other influential works examine donation behavior through psychosocial variables such as consumer identity and social influence. For instance, the research by Gleasure and Feller (2016), which examines the emotional and rational influences on charitable crowdfunding choices, has been cited 115 times, averaging 14.37 citations annually. In a similar vein, the study by André et al. (2017) on reciprocal giving within reward-based crowdfunding has accumulated 81 citations, with an average of 11.57 citations per year, indicating an increasing academic focus on digital giving platforms.

Earlier contributions, such as those of Olsen et al. (2003) and Lowrey et al. (2004), boast high total citation counts (96 and 93, respectively), yet they show lower average citations per year (4.57 and 4.65). This indicates that although these studies have been in the literature for a longer time, their present impact on contemporary scholarship might be somewhat constrained.

Overall, the research indicates that donation behavior is being examined through more multidimensional approaches. Empirical evidence highlights the importance of identity, social influence, and cognitive-affective processes in making donation choices. Additionally, the rise of studies centered on crowdfunding and digital giving environments shows a shift in academic focus toward evolving donation practices. This trend emphasizes the necessity to rethink donation behavior in light of changing media and social dynamics.

4 | The Theory–Context–Characteristics–Methods (TCCM) Framework

4.1 | Theory (T)

This section examines how the theories outlined in Table 3 are applied within the relevant literature for the study subject. Theories provide systematic frameworks for explaining the relationships

TABLE 1 | Most relevant study sources.

Sources	No. of studies	Exemplary studies
<i>International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing</i>	11	Grace and Griffin 2006; Opoku 2013; Tiltay and Torlak 2020
<i>Journal of Nonprofit Public Sector Marketing</i>	10	Gorczyca and Hartman 2017; Rimawati et al. 2025; Aji 2025
<i>International Review on Public and Nonprofit Marketing</i>	6	da Silva et al. 2020; M'Sallem 2022; Silva Carlos and Rodrigues 2024
<i>Psychology & Marketing</i>	6	Mathur 1996; Sargeant and Shang 2011; Kim et al. 2022
<i>Journal of Business Ethics</i>	5	Moir and Taffler 2004; Du 2015; Bock et al. 2018
<i>Journal of Consumer Behaviour</i>	5	Wiepking and Bekkers 2012; Liu et al. 2020; Ho 2024
<i>Journal of Business Research</i>	4	Cermak et al. 1994; Jamal et al. 2019; Borello and Muri 2024
<i>Journal of Consumer Psychology</i>	4	Johnson and Grimm 2010; Klein et al. 2015; Kaikati et al. 2017
<i>Journal of Islamic Marketing</i>	4	Awaliah Kasri 2013; Bin-Nashwan and Al-Daihani 2021; Sabah and Oflazoglu 2024
<i>Journal of Philanthropy and Marketing</i>	4	Müller and Lindenmeier 2022; Quee et al. 2022; Kocaman 2024
<i>Nonprofit Management & Leadership</i>	4	Curtis et al. 2014; Lee and Kim 2023; Liu and Li 2025

TABLE 2 | Principal studies.

Article title	Authors	PY	TC	C/Y
Is Corporate Philanthropy Used as Environmental Misconduct Dressing? Evidence From Chinese Family-Owned Firms	Du	2015	187	20.77
Socially Responsible Consumer Behavior? Exploring Used Clothing Donation Behavior	Ha-Brookshire and Hodges	2009	134	8.93
Crowdfunding Motivations: A Focus on Donors' Perspectives	Bagheri et al.	2019	126	25.20
Does Heart or Head Rule Donor Behaviors in Charitable Crowdfunding Markets?	Gleasure and Feller	2016	115	14.37
When Profit Equals Price: Consumer Confusion About Donation Amounts in Cause-Related Marketing	Olsen et al.	2003	96	4.57
Social Influences on Dyadic Giving Over Time: A Taxonomy from The Giver's Perspective	Lowrey et al.	2004	93	4.65
Fostering Knowledge Sharing Behaviour Among Public Sector Managers: A Proposed Model for The Malaysian Public Service	Tangaraja et al.	2015	90	10
Why Do People Give? The Role of Identity in Giving	Aaker and Akutsu	2009	88	5.86
Beyond The Opposition Between Altruism and Self-Interest: Reciprocal Giving in Reward-Based Crowdfunding	André et al.	2017	81	11.57
Giving Versus Giving In	Cain et al.	Cain et al. 2014	76	7.6

Abbreviations: C/Y, citation per year; PY, publication year; TC, total citations.

between constructs and predicting social behaviors (Rudner 1968). In this context, theoretical approaches to the drivers underpinning the donation behavior clarify the psychological, social, and

economic factors that influence individuals' helping behaviors. Therefore, this section aims to reveal how these theories explain the relevant subject and how they are applied in the literature.

4.1.1 | Self-Determination Theory

SDT Examines How Individuals Fulfill Their Basic Psychological Needs, Autonomy, Competence, and Relatedness when engaging in behaviors such as donating (Burroughs et al. 2013). The theory categorizes motivation into two types: autonomous (internalized) and controlled (driven by external pressures) (Deci and Ryan 2008). Autonomous motivation occurs when an individual perceives donating as aligned with their own values and willingly engages in this behavior. In such instances, the individual experiences satisfaction and positive emotions (Andreoni 1990; Burroughs et al. 2013). In contrast, controlled motivation refers to making donations for reasons such as adhering to external expectations or avoiding negative consequences.

4.1.2 | Theory of Planned Behavior

TPB suggests that behavioral intention plays a key role in predicting an individual's future actions (Luc 2020). This theory indicates that actions such as donating are influenced by a person's readiness and effort to engage in such behavior. TPB asserts that attitudes, perceived behavioral control, and subjective norms significantly impact an individual's intent to donate (Ajzen 1991). This intention is closely linked to actual behavior. The TPB framework is commonly used to model donation intentions and can effectively predict future charitable actions (France et al. 2014). In this context, the motivation to donate is explained by an individual's attitudes and the expectations established by their environment.

4.1.3 | Social Exchange Theory

SET suggests that individuals weigh the benefits and costs of their relationships to decide whether to continue or terminate them (Blau 2017). When it comes to donation behavior, people evaluate their interactions with charitable organizations or trustworthy individuals based on the rewards they gain from these relationships. These rewards may include not just material benefits but also intangible ones, such as social acceptance, acknowledgment, or a sense of community. Perceiving the actions of trustworthy individuals as fair and legitimate may increase the probability of making donations (Tyler and Lind 1992; Cropanzano and Mitchell 2005; Agneessens and Wittek 2012). Consequently, SET provides a framework for understanding how donors relate to aid organizations and how these connections impact their motivation to donate.

4.1.4 | Theory of Prosocial Behaviour

Gebauer et al. (2008) categorize prosocial motivation into two types: pleasure-based and pressure-based.

Pleasure-based motivation stems from the expectation that helping others will generate a sense of well-being and foster positive emotions, such as satisfaction or joy (Martela and Ryan 2016; Jamal et al. 2019). Conversely, pressure-based motivation is driven by the need to adhere to social norms or to evade negative emotions such as guilt (Gebauer et al. 2008). Both types

of motivation are considered egoistic, rooted in individual self-interest rather than altruism (Batson et al. 2008). Batson (1987) suggests that helping behaviors are predominantly performed with the expectation of some personal benefit, highlighting their egoistic nature. Within this framework, the motivation to donate can be understood through egoistic drives linked to pleasure and pressure, including personal satisfaction or the pursuit of social rewards (Hartmann et al. 2017).

4.1.5 | Signaling Theory

Theory posits that charitable behaviors exhibited in public spaces signal high social status because they demonstrate that the individual possesses considerable resources and has the ability to allocate these resources for the benefit of others (Griskevicius et al. 2010). According to this theory, costly prosocial behaviors, such as donations made by individuals, may be performed to illustrate to their surroundings that they have the means to easily engage in these behaviors (Griskevicius et al. 2010; Nelissen and Meijers 2011). Furthermore, such actions by the individual may convey informative signals regarding their status or intentions to their surroundings, potentially triggering the motivation to enhance their reputation (Glazer and Konrad 2008; Bénabou and Tirole 2006). However, when financial incentives are introduced to these behaviors, the authenticity of the individual's charitable intent may be called into question, which could undermine the social signal and diminish the inclination to donate. Consequently, the motivation to donate can be understood through the lens of this theory as an individual's pursuit of status and an effort to elevate their social reputation by making their resources apparent.

Out of the 37 studies reviewed, 13 theories were found to be utilized in just one study each. These theories are consumer storytelling theory, LET, life cycle theory, NAT, person-organization fit theory, self-leadership theory, self-congruity theory, self-identity theory, social learning theory, theory of perceived risk, and theory of reasoned action.

4.2 | Context (C)

4.2.1 | Countries

Analyzing the distribution of studies covered in this review by country reveals that the United States has the highest number, with 27 studies (e.g., Aaker and Akutsu 2009; Bentley 2014; Lehman and James III 2020). Australia follows with 11 studies (e.g., Wierpking and Bekkers 2012; Filo et al. 2020; D'Souza et al. 2023), while the United Kingdom has seven (e.g., Jamal et al. 2019; Pitts et al. 2020; Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023). China reports six studies (e.g., Dubé et al. 2017; Hou et al. 2021; Liu and Li 2025), and Germany has five (e.g., Shehu et al. 2015; Leipnitz et al. 2018; Müller and Lindenmeier 2022). Indonesia, Iran, Spain, and Turkey each have three studies (e.g., Martín-Santana et al. 2018; Haeri et al. 2020; Sabah and Oflazoglu 2024). Additionally, Brazil, South Korea, Malaysia, and the Netherlands each contain two studies (e.g., Teah et al. 2014; Mainardes et al. 2017; Lee and Kim 2023). The review included only one study from various countries such as

TABLE 3 | Theories utilized in reviewed studies.

Theory	Brief description	No. of studies	%	Exemplary studies
Self-determination theory (SDT)	SDT proposes that behavior is regulated by autonomous and controlled motives and that these motives differ experientially (Teixeira et al. 2012).	11	29.73	Pentecost et al. 2017; Cooper and Lu 2019; Yoganathan et al. 2021
Theory of planned behavior (TPB)	TPB argues that the most proximal determinant of behavior is intention; this intention is shaped by attitude, subjective norm, and perceived control (Ajzen and Fishbein 1975; Ajzen 1991).	5	13.51	Charsetad 2016; M'Sallem 2022; Lee and Kim 2023
Social exchange theory (SET)	SET focuses on the effects of perceptions of costs and benefits in relationships on satisfaction (Thibaut and Kelley 1959).	4	10.81	Bentley 2014; Rombach et al. 2018; Bock et al. 2018
Theory of prosocial behavior	It focuses on positive behaviors such as helping and sharing; it does not consider whether the motives are conscious or altruistic (Eisenberg 1982).	2	5.41	Dubé et al. 2017; Aji 2025
Signaling theory	It is fundamentally concerned with reducing information asymmetry between two parties (Spence 2002).	2	5.41	Dubé et al. 2017; Kim et al. 2022
Consumer storytelling theory	It addresses expectations regarding language patterns and the persuasive power of ironic-literal messages (Averbeck 2010).	1	2.70	Aji 2025
Language expectancy theory (LET)	LET addresses expectations in language patterns and provides the basis for a study of the relationship of ironic and literal messages in terms of persuasiveness and expectedness (Averbeck 2010).	1	2.70	Hu et al. 2025
Life cycle theory	It describes cyclical and gradual development processes in which change is inevitable (Balle and Oliveira 2018).	1	2.70	Balle and Oliveira 2018
Norm activation theory (NAT)	NAT argues that personal norms are motivated by awareness of consequences and a sense of responsibility and guide prosocial behavior (Schwartz and Howard 1981; Steg and Vlek 2009).	1	2.70	Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023
Person-organization fit theory	It suggests that the fit between the individual and the organization determines attitudes and behaviors (Kim 2012).	1	2.70	Zhao et al. 2022
Self-leadership theory	It is a self-direction approach that involves managing oneself in tasks that motivate or need to be motivated (Manz 1986).	1	2.70	Mitra et al. 2022
Self-congruity theory	It suggests that individuals gravitate towards experiences and places that align with their self-image.	1	2.70	Fernandes and de Matos 2023
Self-identity theory	It states that consumer behavior is affected by the fit between self-concept and brand image (Sirgy 1982).	1	2.70	Konstantinou and Jones 2022

(Continues)

TABLE 3 | (Continued)

Theory	Brief description	No. of studies	%	Exemplary studies
Social capital theory	It explains that individuals access resources through social relationships and that these relationships are sustained by trust, norms, and cooperation (Putnam 2000).	1	2.70	Tangaraja et al. 2015
Social learning theory	It argues that learning occurs through symbolic representations through modeling (Bandura 1969).	1	2.70	Hou et al. 2021
Theory of perceived risk	It explains the levels of uncertainty and negative outcome expectations of individuals in decision-making processes (Bauer 1960).	1	2.70	Stötzer et al. 2023
Theory of reasoned action	It argues that the probability of a behavior occurring increases with positive evaluation by the individual and his/her significant others (Ajzen and Fishbein 1975).	1	2.70	Siemens et al. 2020
Trust transfer theory	It suggests that trust in a person, institution, or technology can be transferred to other related elements (Stewart 2003).	1	2.70	Hou et al. 2021

Austria, Ghana, India, Israel, Italy, Kuwait, Oman, Portugal, Saudi Arabia, Taiwan, Tunisia, Ireland, Canada, and Palestine. This is illustrated in Figure 2, which shows the distribution of countries where two or more studies were conducted.

This distribution shows that the existing literature is predominantly Western-centric, particularly in Anglo-Saxon nations. The United States, hosting the majority of studies, reflects not only significant academic interest but also considerable financial and institutional support dedicated to research in this field. Similarly, the representation of countries like Australia, the United Kingdom, and Canada with a substantial number of studies suggests that donation behavior has emerged as a vital topic of research in these nations, socially and scientifically. Factors such as a robust civil society, a well-established donation culture, and accessible data contribute to the concentration of research in these countries. On the other hand, the few studies conducted in developing countries or those with different socio-cultural backgrounds show that current knowledge is essentially uniform. For instance, representation from regions such as the Middle East, Africa, and Southeast Asia is notably underrepresented. This lack of diversity may hinder the development of a more comprehensive understanding of how cultural, religious, economic, and political contexts influence donation behavior. The existing literature's imbalance not only highlights the limited scope of current knowledge but also underscores the necessity for research that enables cross-cultural comparisons of donation motivations. Therefore, future studies should aim to include a broader range of countries from various regions, thereby contributing to a more comprehensive understanding of the cultural, structural, and normative variations in donation behavior.

4.3 | Characteristics (C)

The variables used in the reviewed studies represent the fundamental components of the research that explores the complex nature of the study subject from various perspectives (Table 3). The underlying reasons for selecting these variables are to comprehend the mechanisms that influence donation intention and behavior, as well as the facilitating and inhibiting factors, mediating processes, and external influences that need to be managed.

4.3.1 | Antecedents

Antecedents are considered the primary factors influencing donation motivation and behavior. Analyzing these antecedents helps uncover the different reasons and external factors that encourage or deter individuals from donating. The most commonly examined antecedents across the studies reviewed were "Motivational factors" (24 studies). These factors, including altruism, empathy, personal fulfillment, philanthropy, power-seeking, social recognition, and self-image or self-esteem, highlight the significant research interest in exploring the psychological and intrinsic motivators behind charitable giving (Brady et al. 2002; Curtis et al. 2014; Minguez and Sese 2023). In related studies, it is possible to classify donation motivations not only by their content but also by their structural characteristics.

In this context, distinctions can be made between intrinsic (e.g., helpfulness, empathy) and extrinsic (e.g., social recognition, gaining power) motivations; rational (e.g., cost–benefit analysis) and emotional (e.g., guilt, conscience)-based motivations; and short-term (one-time donation) and long-term (continuous support) tendencies. These structural characteristics are important in determining the type and duration of donation behavior.

The antecedents “Individual and demographic characteristics” (18 studies) investigate how personal traits and demographic aspects such as household income, materialism, religiosity, and education influence the likelihood of donating (Zhou et al. 2012; Tiltay and Torlak 2020; Sabah and Oflazoğlu 2024). The antecedents of literature on individual motivations generally emphasize emotional and value-based motivations such as empathy, religious beliefs, personal values, and a sense of social responsibility. These motivations are particularly influential in small-scale, frequently repeated donations. “Institution and project-related factors” (13 studies) analyze how specific project and institutional features, including project quality, brand image, brand orientation, operational costs, and organizational reliability, affect the decisions of potential donors (Turrini et al. 2020; Stötzer et al. 2023; D’Souza et al. 2023). On the other hand, for corporate donors, motivations are more closely tied to strategic objectives. Extrinsic motivations such as corporate social responsibility practices, brand reputation, stakeholder expectations, and tax advantages drive corporate giving behavior. This suggests that organizations base their giving decisions on rational and strategic analysis. Likewise, “Communication, message and platform-based factors” (13 studies) explore how communication approaches and platform characteristics such as storytelling, endorsements by influencers, visual appeal, donation calls, and media coverage influence donation motivation (Zhou et al. 2012; Wallace and Buil 2021; Quee et al. 2022). “External and situational factors” (8 studies) reveal that elements like financial commitment, price level, candidate type, and donor involvement significantly impact donation decisions (Dubé et al. 2017; Gao et al. 2021; Borello and Muri 2024). “Perceptual factors” (7 studies) focus on cognitive perceptions, including perceived behavioral control, perceived relatedness, perceived need, and perceived ability, which play a crucial role in the donation process (Johnson and Grimm 2010; Charsetad 2016; Fernandes and de Matos 2023). “Incentives and reciprocity-related factors” (7 studies) explore how incentives and reciprocity elements, like payback rate, incentive amount, rewards, or health benefits, can enhance the motivation to donate (Mitra et al. 2022; Hu et al. 2025). Lastly, “Type and scope of donation” (7 studies) shows how donation characteristics, such as donation level, diversity, or percentage value, influence both the intention to donate and the total amount (Olsen et al. 2003; Dubé et al. 2017; Khan et al. 2020). Antecedents that are less frequently studied yet significant include “Social and normative-based factors” (6 studies), which reflect the impact of the social environment and norms, including social norms, peer influence, shared identity salience, and social influence (Otoo and Amuquandoh 2014; Tiltay and Torlak 2020; Nisar et al. 2022); “Attitudes” (4 studies), referring to cognitive dispositions such as attitudes toward NGOs or the importance of need (Zhou et al. 2012; Teah et al. 2014; Gorczyca and Hartman 2017); “Propensity/inclination to donate” (4 studies), which encompasses predispositions like the inclination to donate or philanthropic intention (Brady

et al. 2002; Otoo and Amuquandoh 2014; Kim et al. 2019); and “Donor and institution relationship-based factors” (3 studies), which pertain to the relationship dynamics between the donor and the institution, including perceived exchange relationships, membership tenure, or commitment (Johnson and Grimm 2010; Ki and Oh 2018; Kim et al. 2019).

This collection of antecedents underscores that the motivation to donate emerges from a complex interplay of various intrinsic and extrinsic factors (Table 4).

4.3.2 | Outcomes

The most commonly examined outcomes in the reviewed papers were “Donation behavior” (20 studies). This includes specific behavioral metrics such as the frequency of donations, corporate philanthropic contributions, sharing behaviors, or past giving actions, highlighting researchers’ primary focus on how motivation ultimately translates into tangible actions (Edmondson and Carroll 1999; Awaliah Kasri 2013; Peterson et al. 2021; Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023). Donation behavior is a critical outcome variable because it reflects the translation of motivational factors into behavioral outcomes at the individual or organizational level. In the literature, intrinsic motives (e.g., altruism, conscientiousness) (e.g., Castiglioni et al. 2019; Kolhede and Gomez-Arias 2022a) are generally associated with frequent and small-scale individual donations, while extrinsic motives (e.g., social recognition, tax advantages) predict larger or institutional donations (e.g., Feine et al. 2023; Goette and Tripodi 2024). The category of “Donation intention and propensity-based factors” (15 studies) encompasses concepts like the desire or willingness to donate. Metrics such as the intention to contribute to crowdfunding or the readiness to support charities are critical for evaluating the potential for motivational factors in scenarios where behavior is not immediate or is assessed at the intention stage (Curtis et al. 2014; Heger et al. 2020). Intention-level outcomes are crucial for understanding the potential for motivational factors to translate into donations, particularly in contexts where the behavior has not yet occurred. Such intentions are influenced by factors such as uncertainty surrounding the donation decision, level of trust, and platform experience. In an institutional context, donation intentions are often shaped by organizational reputation, social pressure, or managerial decisions. Finally, “Donation motivation-related factors” (10 studies) investigate the distinct motivations that influence donations as outcomes. Factors such as the desire to contribute to crowdfunding or the urge to donate blood are studied to determine which motivations lead to specific donation types or situations (Otoo and Amuquandoh 2014; Khan et al. 2020; Quee et al. 2022). “Organization/platform related consequences” (9 studies) focus on the organizational results of the donation process as outcomes, including the likelihood of recommending an organization or platform, volunteer loyalty, or the creation of new offerings. This highlights the impact of donations not only on individuals but also on the organizations being supported (Dubé et al. 2017; Zhao et al. 2022; Zaborek et al. 2025). Organizational outcomes demonstrate that donation processes impact not only individual but also organizational performance, sustainability, and innovation capacity. Affective outcomes, such as trust and loyalty, in particular, shape how organizations

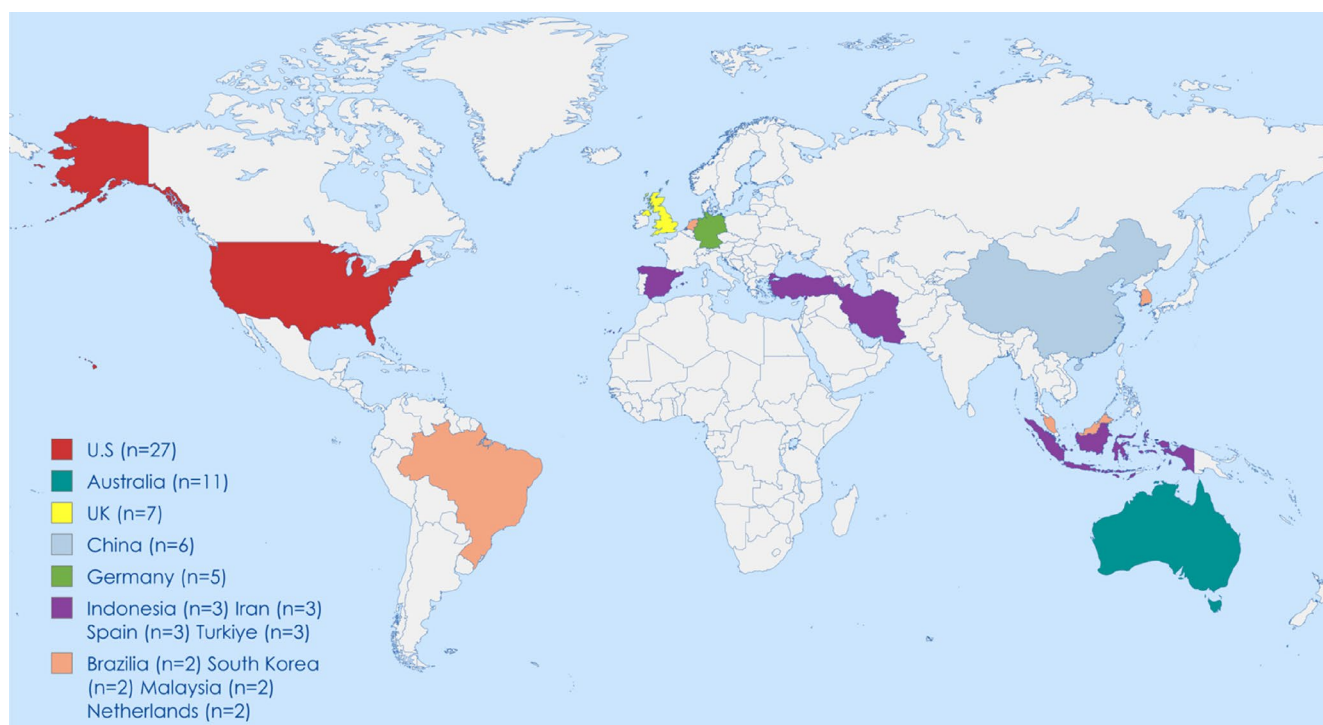


FIGURE 2 | Countries investigated in the relevant research field.

manage long-term donor relationships (e.g., Fernandes and de Matos 2023; Stötzer et al. 2023). “Psychological and individual consequences” (8 studies) consider psychological outcomes like ego benefit, self-identity, amotivation, and the quest for meaning in life. These outcomes aim to understand the psychological or personal impact of donating on individuals (Shehu et al. 2015; Pentecost et al. 2017; Sherman and Axelrad 2021). Individual-level psychological outcomes describe the subjective meaning of giving. Intrinsic motivations have been shown to have positive effects, such as post-donation “feeling good,” gaining social identity, and a sense of belonging (e.g., Randle et al. 2016; Sherman and Axelrad 2021). Such effects also provide a motivational basis for future giving behavior. Amount-related factors (6 studies) explore how motivation influences both the act of donating and the amount contributed, using financial outcomes like the total amount donated or overall funding as outcomes (Kim and Kou 2014; Khodakarami et al. 2015; Ki and Oh 2018). Financial outcomes, such as donation amounts, reveal the effects of motivation types on economic behavior. The literature indicates that extrinsic motivations (e.g., tax deductions, rewards) increase donation amounts, while intrinsic motivations provide greater continuity (e.g., Harbaugh 1998; Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). Finally, donation success-related consequences (4 studies) assess how the motivation to donate results in concrete success, particularly on a campaign or project level, employing outcomes such as the success of the donation or funds raised as outcomes (André et al. 2017; Frimpong et al. 2024; Hu et al. 2025).

4.3.3 | Moderators

The variable category that was most often studied as a moderator is “Individual and demographic characteristics” (10 studies). Examining factors like political ideology, gender, religious

beliefs, and knowledge of NGOs as moderators aims to illustrate how identical motivational aspects influence donation intentions or behaviors distinctively across different individuals (Zhou et al. 2012; Opoku 2013; Ho 2024). These variables reveal that individual donation motivations are not fixed and homogeneous; on the contrary, individual differences such as gender, ideological orientation, or religious values can cause the same motivations to translate into different behavioral outcomes. Deep identity elements, particularly religious beliefs or political leanings, have been shown to play a significant role in determining which motivations become more dominant in donation decisions. For example, a study by Kaikati et al. (2017) revealed that individuals’ ideological values and perceptions of political accountability shape donation motivations by increasing their search for social approval. The category “Organization, project, and appeal characteristics” (9 studies) assesses how specific traits of organizations, projects, and appeals, such as campaign type, source credibility, or project scale, affect the relationship between antecedents and donation motivation. This indicates that the traits of the organization or project receiving the donation can influence donor reactions (Kim et al. 2022; Borello and Muri 2024; Frimpong et al. 2024). The moderating effect of institutional characteristics demonstrates that donation behavior is shaped not only by individual factors but also by the characteristics of the donor organization. Variables such as source credibility, campaign language, or scale can influence intermediary mechanisms such as trust, value congruence, and emotional resonance in the process of transforming motivation into behavior. Cryder and Loewenstein (2012) demonstrated that the credibility of charities and their messages calling for emotional responsibility increases the likelihood of donation by triggering trust and empathy in donors. Similarly, Bekkers and Wiepking (2011) argue that factors such as institutional recognition, visibility, and transparency influence donors’ decisions to donate not directly,

but through mediating psychological mechanisms such as trust, emotional resonance, and value congruence. These findings demonstrate that the characteristics of the donor organization are crucial in the process of transforming motivation into behavior. Finally, “Situational and external factors” (7 studies) investigate how circumstances and external influences, including awareness of the repercussions of not donating, repayment rates, and controllability, render the connection between antecedents and donation motivation context-sensitive (Leipnitz et al. 2018; Heger et al. 2020; Song and Ferguson 2023). Situational and environmental factors highlight the contextual sensitivity of donation decisions. For example, the motivation to donate after a natural disaster may not be the same as the motivation that arises during a routine campaign. Such factors can alter motivational effects by increasing emotional response or a sense of urgency, particularly through psychological stimuli such as awareness of the consequences of not helping. Finally, “Social and relational factors” (6 studies) are used to examine how these factors, such as social norms, political identity activation, cultural distance, and local donor participation, affect the impact of antecedents on donation motivation within social and relational contexts (Zhou et al. 2012; Gao et al. 2021; Xie et al. 2024). The moderating role of social and relational factors is important for understanding how donation behavior is shaped by social norms and belonging. Particularly in cultures where social norms are prevalent, donations may become a means of conforming to social expectations rather than an individual decision, while the level of participation of local donors can reinforce motivation through a sense of belonging to the community (e.g., Gao et al. 2021; Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023).

4.3.4 | Mediators

The primary variable examined as a mediator across the studies is the different types of “Motivations” (9 studies). These motivations, including protection motivation, development motivation, and prosocial motivation, are explored to understand how internal responses to external stimuli or personal traits influence donation intentions (Kaikati et al. 2017; Bock et al. 2018; Mitra et al. 2022). These findings suggest that donation behaviors are mediated not only by external factors but also by internal responses to these external stimuli (e.g., protective motivation, desire for growth, desire to help others). In this context, motivation serves as a critical moderator that triggers donation behaviors when individuals feel threatened or perceive opportunities for growth. Attitude (8 studies) plays a significant role as a mediator in the process of donation motivation. Individuals' attitudes towards poverty, donations, brands, or non-profit organizations illustrate how their cognitive and emotional responses to external information or internal values translate into donation behavior (Teah et al. 2014; Martín-Santana et al. 2018; M'Sallem 2022). Attitude serves as a conceptual bridge in donation decisions, where both rational (e.g., cognitive appraisals of poverty) and emotional (e.g., belief in the moral responsibility of giving) components come together to shape individuals' likelihood of donating. Therefore, attitude change is examined as a key determinant of both donation motivation and behavioral outcomes. Next, “Perceptual factors” (6 studies) demonstrate how elements like risk perception, resource need perception, or trustworthiness perception influence the decision-making process related

to donations (Kasri and Indriani 2022; Borello and Muri 2024; Ho 2024). In a similar vein, “Trust-related factors” (5 studies) are investigated as mediators to understand how trust in entities like crowdfunding platforms or beneficiaries, specifically, affects the relationship between potential donors and their donations (Stötzer et al. 2023; Lee and Kim 2023; D'Souza et al. 2023). “Relationship and identification-related factors” (4 studies) serve as mediating mechanisms that illustrate how aspects such as commitment, relationship quality, and identification with the organizational identity influence an individual's motivation to donate (Kasri and Indriani 2022; Song and Ferguson 2023; D'Souza et al. 2023). When individuals see themselves as part of an organization or engage in a long-term relationship, it not only fuels their motivation but also helps transform that motivation into loyalty. In this context, identification with the corporate identity plays a powerful mediating role in transforming intrinsic motivation into giving behavior. Finally, “Emotional response-based factors” (3 studies) and “Perceived value and satisfaction related factors” (3 studies) indicate that elements such as positive or negative emotions and perceived value or satisfaction mediate the influence of particular situations or traits on donation motivation through emotional or evaluative means (Brady et al. 2002; Beerli-Palacio and Martín-Santana 2009; Randle et al. 2016; Fernandes and de Matos 2023). Factors such as emotional reactions (e.g., guilt, pride, empathy) and perceived value play a significant role in individuals' decision-making processes, particularly in highly emotionally charged fundraising campaigns. Such mediating variables provide important evidence that donors are motivated not only by rational but also emotional considerations.

4.3.5 | Control Variables

The most commonly utilized control variable in the reviewed studies was “Demographic and individual characteristics” (17 studies). By controlling for factors such as religiosity, education, income, age, gender, and environmental concern, researchers can observe the effect of the antecedent without the influence of these characteristics (Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023; Stötzer et al. 2023; Konrath et al. 2024). Because these variables may mask the underlying tendencies that shape individuals' motivations for giving, controlling for them allows for a more accurate interpretation of the cause-and-effect relationships between individual giving behaviors. For example, religiosity may influence giving behavior through both intrinsic motivation and social norms, and therefore needs to be disaggregated. “Project, campaign and platform-related characteristics” (6 studies) serve to clarify how donation motivation is influenced by the specific features of the project or platform by accounting for aspects like project purpose or type, crowdfunding initiator attributes, or platform structure (André et al. 2017; Ryu et al. 2020; Xie et al. 2024). Including campaign or platform characteristics as control variables allows for the analysis of context-driven variations in motivational effects. For example, the urgency of the campaign or the technical security of the platform can directly influence the intensity of motivational responses in donation decisions (e.g., Ryu et al. 2020; Zhao et al. 2022). In this context, a more refined understanding of platform-based donation motivation is provided. Finally, “Experiential and behavioral factors” (3 studies) evaluate how past behaviors or experiences impact current donation

TABLE 4 | Key characteristics in studies.

Variables	No. of studies	Sample variables	Exemplary studies
<i>Antecedents</i>			
Motivational factors	24	Altruism Empathy Personal satisfaction Philanthropy Seeking power Social recognition Self-image Self-esteem	Brady et al. 2002; Curtis et al. 2014; Minguez and Sese 2023
Individual and demographic characteristics	18	Household income Materialism Religiosity Education	Zhou et al. 2012; Tiltay and Torlak 2020; Sabah and Oflazoğlu 2024
Institution and project-related factors	13	Project quality Brand image Brand orientation Operational expenditures Organizational credibility	Turrini et al. 2020; Stötzer et al. 2023; D'Souza et al. 2023
Communication, message, and platform-based factors	13	Storytelling Influencer endorsement Visual appeal Call for donation Media attention	Zhou et al. 2012; Wallace and Buil 2021; Quee et al. 2022
External and situational factors	8	Financial commitment Price level Candidate type Level of donor participation Lender behavior in crowdfunding	Dubé et al. 2017; Gao et al. 2021; Borello and Muri 2024
Perceptual factors	7	Perceived behavioral control Perceived relatedness Perceived need Perceived ability	Johnson and Grimm 2010; Charsetad 2016; Fernandes and de Matos 2023
Incentives and reciprocation-related factors	7	Rebate rate Incentive amount Rewards Health benefits	Mitra et al. 2022; Hu et al. 2025; Hu et al. 2025
Type and scope of donation	7	Donation level Donation variety Percentage value of donation	Olsen et al. 2003; Dubé et al. 2017; Khan et al. 2020
Social and normative-based factors	6	Perceived behavioral control Peer influence Shared identity salience Social impact	Otoo and Amuquandoh 2014; Tiltay and Torlak 2020; Nisar et al. 2022
Attitudes	4	Attitudes towards NPOs Significance of NPOs Importance of need	Zhou et al. 2012; Teah et al. 2014; Gorczyca and Hartman 2017
Propensity/inclination to donate	4	Predisposition to donation Philanthropic intention	Brady et al. 2002; Otoo and Amuquandoh 2014; Kim et al. 2019

(Continues)

TABLE 4 | (Continued)

Variables	No. of studies	Sample variables	Exemplary studies
Donor and institution relationship-based factors	3	Perceived exchange relationship Membership duration Commitment	Johnson and Grimm 2010; Ki and Oh 2018; Kim et al. 2019
<i>Outcomes</i>			
Donation behavior	20	Frequency of giving Corporate philanthropic giving Sharing behavior Prior giving behavior Presence of a will	Edmondson and Carroll 1999; Awaliah Kasri 2013; Peterson et al. 2021; Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023
Donation intention and propensity-based factors	15	Donation intention to crowdfunding Willingness to donate Intention to donate Willingness to support NPOs	Curtis et al. 2014; Curtis et al. 2014; Heger et al. 2020
Donation motivation-related factors	10	Motivation to contribute to crowdfunding Motivation to volunteer Motivation to donate Blood donation motivation	Otoo and Amuquandoh 2014; Khan et al. 2020; Quee et al. 2022
Organization/platform related consequences	9	Intention to recommend Volunteers' loyalty to the NPOs Developing new offerings	Dubé et al. 2017; Zhao et al. 2022; Zaborek et al. 2025
Psychological and individual consequences	8	Ego utility Self-identity Amotivation Meaning in life	Shehu et al. 2015; Pentecost et al. 2017; Sherman and Axelrad 2021
Amount-related factors	6	Donation amount Percentage value of donation Funding amount	Kim and Kou 2014; Khodakarami et al. 2015; Ki and Oh 2018
Donation success related consequences	4	Success of donation Raised funds Fundraising performance	André et al. 2017; Frimpong et al. 2024; Hu et al. 2025
<i>Moderators</i>			
Individual and demographic characteristics	10	Political ideology Gender Religious beliefs Familiarity with NPOs	Zhou et al. 2012; Opoku 2013; Ho 2024
Organization, project, and appeal characteristics	9	Campaign type Source reputation Project bundle size	Kim et al. 2022; Borello and Muri 2024; Frimpong et al. 2024
Situational and external factors	7	Awareness of consequences of not giving Rebate rate Controllability	Leipnitz et al. 2018; Heger et al. 2020; Song and Ferguson 2023
Social and relational factors	6	Social norms Political identity activation Cultural distance Local donor participation	Zhou et al. 2012; Gao et al. 2021; Xie et al. 2024

(Continues)

TABLE 4 | (Continued)

Variables	No. of studies	Sample variables	Exemplary studies
<i>Mediators</i>			
Motivations	9	Protection motivation Enhancement motivation Prosocial motivation	Kaikati et al. 2017; Bock et al. 2018; Mitra et al. 2022
Attitude	8	Attitude regarding poverty Attitude toward donation Attitude towards brand Attitude towards NPOs	Teah et al. 2014; Martín-Santana et al. 2018; M'Sallem 2022
Perceptual factors	6	Changing risk perceptions Perceived of resource need Perceived credibility	Kasri and Indriani 2022; Borello and Muri 2024; Ho 2024
Trust-related factors	5	Trust in social crowdfunding platforms Trust in beneficiary Risk reduction for donors	Stötzer et al. 2023; Lee and Kim 2023; D'Souza et al. 2023
Relationship and identification-related factors	4	Commitment Relationship quality Identification with the corporation	Kasri and Indriani 2022; Song and Ferguson 2023; D'Souza et al. 2023
Emotional response-based factors	3	Positive emotions Negative emotions Intolerance	Beerli-Palacio and Martín-Santana 2009; Randle et al. 2016; Hsieh and Yucel-Aybat 2018
Perceived value and satisfaction-related factors	3	Value Satisfaction Ego utility	Brady et al. 2002; Dubé et al. 2017; Fernandes and de Matos 2023
<i>Control variables</i>			
Demographic and individual characteristics	17	Religiosity Education Income Age Gender Environmental concern	Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023; Stötzer et al. 2023; Konrath et al. 2024
Project, campaign, and platform-related characteristics	6	Project goal Project type Crowdfunder characteristic Loan proportion Platform tenure	André et al. 2017; Ryu et al. 2020; Xie et al. 2024
Experiential and behavioral factors	3	Past donation experience Time since first donation Previous lending history	Khodakarami et al. 2015; Zhao et al. 2022; Kasri and Indriani 2022

motivation by examining variables like prior donation experience or previous lending history (Khodakarami et al. 2015; Zhao et al. 2022; Kasri and Indriani 2022). Experiential factors, such as prior giving experience or past interactions, can influence individuals' motivation to donate in both reinforcing (e.g., forming a giving habit, receiving positive feedback) and transformative ways (e.g., searching for meaning after a disaster, feeling insecure about a past negative aid experience) (e.g., Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023; Wiepking and Bekkers 2012). Controlling for these factors allows testing motivational effects independent of temporal and behavioral contexts.

4.3.6 | Drivers to Donate

In the reviewed studies, motivations are positioned as the basic driving force that triggers and directs donation behavior, divided into two categories: intrinsic motivations, which are fed by the individual's inner world, and extrinsic motivations, which originate from the individual's social and environmental context.

4.3.6.1 | Extrinsic Motivations. Driving forces encompass expectations shaped by the donor's social context, social norms, visibility, and the quest for influence. The need for social

recognition and status reflects an individual's aim to earn respect within society, enhance their reputation, and bolster their social capital through charitable contributions (Kim et al. 2019; Kim et al. 2022). The pursuit of power suggests that donations can serve as instruments of influence and control (Kim et al. 2019). Specifically, business motivations arise when corporate entities leverage their contributions as strategic tools, aiming for external benefits like corporate social responsibility objectives, brand image enhancement, stakeholder relations, and even competitive advantage (Moir and Taffler 2004). Signaling generosity illustrates the efforts of individuals or institutions to convey a desired social identity (e.g., helpfulness) to the public (Kim et al. 2022).

4.3.6.2 | Intrinsic Motivations. These motivations, arising from an individual's values, moral compass, emotional resonance, and pursuit of personal meaning, aim for internal satisfaction distinct from external rewards. Personal satisfaction and warm-glow giving refer to the positive emotional return that an individual gains from this action, beyond merely helping others (Opoku 2013; Gleasure and Feller 2016). Self-image fulfills the individual's need to see himself as a helpful, sensitive, and moral person and to demonstrate behaviors that align with this self-perception (Opoku 2013). The desire to alleviate the suffering of others, coupled with a strong sense of empathy, underpins the wish to help, particularly for individuals or groups in challenging circumstances (Kim and Kou 2014). Seeking congruence leads the individual to engage with people, groups, or causes that they believe share similar values or with which they identify (Kocaman 2024). Prosocial motivations, in contrast, encompass fundamental human motives from a broader perspective, such as enhancing social good and contributing to collective welfare (Song and Ferguson 2023). The studies highlight that intrinsic and extrinsic motivations are interdependent; they often support, compete with, and interact within a dynamic network that varies in influence based on the type of donation, chosen channel, or target audience (Figure 3). For instance, analyzing corporate donation decisions reveals that these may serve the dual purpose of achieving external legitimacy and enhancing brand reputation (extrinsic motivation), while also promoting shared values and boosting internal prestige and employee belonging (which can include elements of intrinsic motivation). This illustrates that motivations are frequently interconnected and influence one another, rather than existing in isolation (Peterson et al. 2021).

4.3.7 | Benefactors

Donors consist of individuals, groups, or institutions providing resources and support to those in need or for specific causes. Individual donors contribute from their personal savings or income (Frimpong et al. 2024). Corporate donors are companies that give within social responsibility initiatives or for commercial objectives (Gleasure and Feller 2016). Crowdfunding donors involve groups formed by many individuals, typically contributing small amounts through platforms (Xie et al. 2024). Meanwhile, multiple donors refer to individuals or organizations that give various types of donations or use different channels (Edmondson and Carroll 1999). Donors' decisions on giving and the donation process are shaped by intrinsic and extrinsic

motivations. The motivational priorities, decision-making processes, resource capabilities, and relationship expectations vary among each donor type, necessitating nonprofit organizations to adjust their strategies accordingly.

Differences in donor profiles offer important clues about the building blocks of motivation. While individual donors are generally driven by intrinsic motivations such as empathy, conscientiousness, and personal fulfillment (Sargeant and Woodliffe 2007a, 2007b; Bekkers and Wiepking 2011), extrinsic factors such as social recognition or social status can also shape donation behavior (Haruvy and Popkowski Leszczyc 2022a, 2022b). For corporate donors, motivations are often based on strategic interests, corporate reputation management, and stakeholder expectations (Saiia et al. 2003; Moir and Taffler 2004), potentially directly impacting donation volume, channel choices, and sustainability. Crowdfunding donors, on the other hand, are motivated by factors such as social interaction, peer pressure, and a sense of community (Saxton and Wang 2014), which can lead to donations of small amounts but large participation. Therefore, donation motivations vary depending on the type of donor and the context and determine the nature of donation behavior.

4.3.8 | Beneficiaries

Beneficiaries represent the ultimate point at which donations are transformed into tangible value, fulfilling needs and giving meaning to the act of giving. They may encompass individuals, groups, institutions, or causes that benefit directly or indirectly from donations. The identity of the beneficiaries and the perceived urgency or legitimacy of their needs can significantly influence donor motivations and decisions. Healthcare beneficiaries are individuals reached through donations for initiatives like patient care or healthcare infrastructure development (Borello and Muri 2024). Recipients of biological donations include patients requiring blood or organ transplants, constituting a vital group (Haeri et al. 2020). Food aid recipients are those struggling to meet basic nutritional needs or affected by natural disasters, often assisted by food banks and emergency relief programs (Haruvy and Popkowski Leszczyc 2022a, 2022b). Educational beneficiaries encompass students and educational institutions benefiting from donations for scholarships, school construction, or educational resources (Liu and Li 2025). Beneficiaries in the cultural and arts sector receive donations that promote artistic endeavors or preserve cultural heritage (Bertacchini et al. 2011; Pitts et al. 2020). Social and economic development beneficiaries include individuals or communities supported by corporate giving or initiatives from social enterprises aimed at creating lasting social impact (Stötzer et al. 2023). Civic and political initiative beneficiaries are political parties or candidates that receive contributions during elections (Ho 2024). Cause-specific or community-based beneficiaries involve donations addressing specific needs or community objectives (Haruvy and Popkowski Leszczyc 2022a, 2022b). The category of other beneficiaries comprises individuals or institutions that do not fit neatly into the previously mentioned groups but still gain from donations in various capacities (e.g., Randle et al. 2016; Turrini et al. 2020). The needs of beneficiaries, along with

their urgency, significantly influence donor motivations and the nature and focus of charitable contributions.

The specific area in which donations are directed is a critical factor in determining donor motivations and the outcomes of donation behavior. In particular, in situations involving urgent needs such as healthcare or disaster relief, donors are often motivated by emotionally intense intrinsic motivations to give quickly and in large amounts (Einolf 2011; Haruvy and Popkowski Leszczyc 2022a, 2022b). In contrast, donations to arts and culture or social development are shaped more by personal interests, alignment with societal values, and the strategic goals of the institution (Bertacchini et al. 2011). The nature of the donation target also influences donor trust and the sustainability of the donation; for example, the long-term impact of education or social development projects may increase donors' likelihood of repeat donations (Sargeant and Woodliffe 2007a, 2007b; Bekkers and Wiepking 2011).

4.3.9 | Channels

Channels refer to the tools and methods through which donors provide their contributions to beneficiaries. The studies examined present two ways of donation: direct and indirect. However, most studies focus on indirect donations through multiple channels. Crowdfunding platforms serve as online or offline intermediaries that gather small donations from a large number of individuals. Nonprofit and charitable organizations utilize the donations they receive for specific social objectives (Curtis et al. 2014), while corporate and business initiatives include fundraising campaigns and social responsibility projects conducted by companies either independently or in collaboration (Sargeant and Shang 2011). Fundraising events and campaigns are organized efforts aimed at raising awareness and securing resources for particular causes (D'Souza et al. 2023). In contrast, digital and online channels facilitate donations via technologies such as websites, social media, and mobile apps (Borello and Muri 2024). These donation channels play a crucial role in influencing the effectiveness, transparency, and accessibility of the donation process.

The literature emphasizes that donor channel selection varies based on donors' motivations and personality traits. For example, donors with high intrinsic motivations prefer to donate quickly and anonymously through the organization's website; "skeptical" donors seeking information tend to opt for channels that provide detailed project data. "Impressionable" donors, who are more influenced by social influence and group pressure, prefer to donate through collective channels such as workplace campaigns or in-person fundraisers (Shang and Croson 2009; Kolhede and Gomez-Arias 2022a, 2022b). These findings suggest that donation channels should be designed to align with individual motivations.

Furthermore, digital channels can both strengthen and weaken donation motivations. While social media and mobile applications facilitate the donation process and increase small and spontaneous donations (Bennett and Kottasz 2012; Saxton and Wang 2014), trust issues in the online environment and concerns about personal data being misused can lead to hesitation,

especially among donors motivated by external motivations (Beldad et al. 2011). Therefore, channels influence the visibility, speed, and perceived credibility of donations, thus significantly shaping how motivations translate into behavior.

4.3.10 | Donation Types

Types of donations encompass various forms of resources that donors contribute to beneficiaries. The most prevalent form is monetary donations, which consist of financial contributions made via cash or bank transfers (Bagheri et al. 2019). Since such donations are often shaped by the donor's economic capacity, tax incentives, and corporate social responsibility goals, the impact of extrinsic motivations is more pronounced in these types of donations (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). In-kind donations involve contributions in the form of goods or services, rather than money, such as clothing, food, or equipment (Ha-Brookshire and Hodges 2009). Bequest donations are those in which individuals designate part or all of their estate to nonprofits upon their passing (Sargeant and Shang 2011). In testamentary donations, both internal and external motivations play an important role, such as the donor's desire to "create a posthumous impact," perception of moral responsibility, and desire to leave a social legacy (James III 2019). Multiple or hybrid donations describe instances where different types of donations are combined (Pentecost and Andrews 2010). Time donations involve individuals willingly dedicating their time and effort to support a cause (Fernandes and de Matos 2023). In this type of giving, intrinsic motivations such as altruism, social belonging, and the desire to strengthen community ties predominate; however, extrinsic motivations such as career advancement, expanding social networks, and gaining visibility may also be influential (Clary et al. 1998). Biological donations encompass critical contributions, including blood, organ, or tissue donations from individuals (Haeri et al. 2020). Knowledge and skill donations consist of individuals providing their expertise, skills, or talents to benefit an organization or project (Tangaraja et al. 2015).

Donations come in various forms, depending on the donor's resources, motivations, and the needs of recipients. These different types demonstrate the array of assets and intentions among donors, enabling their motivations to translate into tangible actions. Each donation type signifies a unique level of commitment, allocation of resources, and potential impact.

The drivers-to-donate model (Figure 3), informed by the data gathered from the studies reviewed, conceptualizes the donation process as a multi-layered approach influenced by both internal and external dynamics, rather than as a simplistic decision-making mechanism. This model highlights that donation involves profound psychological and social dynamics that extend beyond a mere financial transaction by illustrating the fundamental elements that trigger and shape donation behavior as well as the complex interaction network among these elements. It also outlines the critical components in the broader journey from diverse donor profiles to the primary motivational sources that activate these profiles, including the communication and distribution channels through which donations are transferred, and ultimately the beneficiaries reached. Donation drivers, comprising both internal and external motivations,

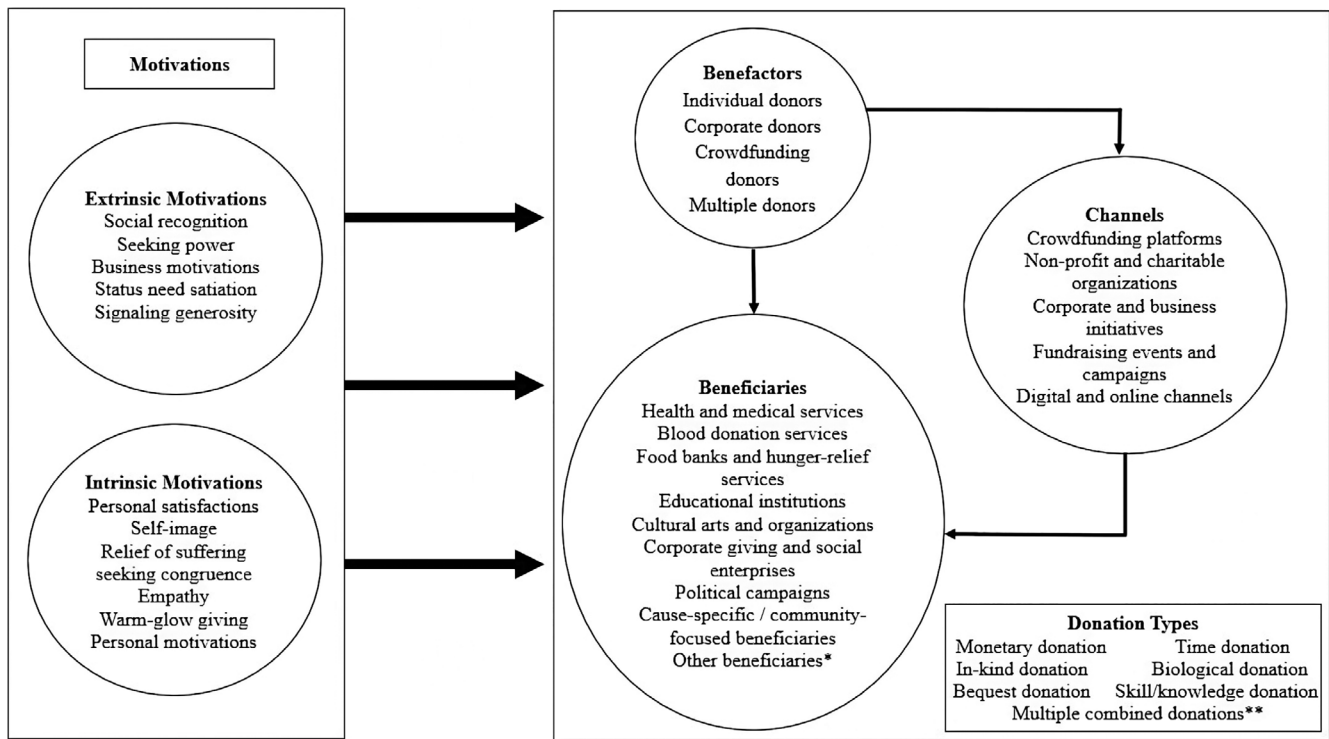


FIGURE 3 | Drivers to donate model (DDM).

serve as the essential force that propels the entire mechanism. Various motivations of individuals or institutions, such as social recognition, satisfaction, empathy, or the pursuit of status, lead them to become benefactors. Donors may have different identities, including individual, corporate, or crowdfunding, and they seek to deliver their donations, whether directly or indirectly, to beneficiaries in accordance with their motivations. The drivers of donation behavior impact not only the choice to give but also the kind of donation and the method of delivery. For instance, a donor who values social recognition might opt for a prominent channel and an eye-catching donation type, while an empathetic donor may select a method that ensures rapid and direct assistance to the most pressing needs. Consequently, each component of this model interacts dynamically with others, requiring separate and interconnected evaluation to fully grasp donation behavior. Viewing donation behavior as a dynamic social practice highlights its emergence from a complex network of interactions among individuals' and institutions' psychological processes and the surrounding social and environmental contexts. It encompasses both digital and traditional channels, extending beyond a simple financial transaction. Thus, the motivations for donating, the various means of making donations, and the resulting impacts are all intricately linked.

The DDM model demonstrates that the donation process is not merely a one-way transfer of resources, but rather a network of multidimensional, mutually reinforcing relationships. Motivations are the starting point of the process, enabling individuals or institutions to adopt the benefactor identity. Intrinsic motivations (e.g., empathy, altruism, personal fulfillment) form the emotional and moral basis of donations, while extrinsic motivations (e.g., social recognition, status, power-seeking)

shape the social capital and visibility dimensions of donations. Furthermore, the motivational construct is not limited to these two categories; mixed motivations (intrinsic–extrinsic interactions) and situational motivations (e.g., sudden donations during crises, disasters, or social trends) are important additional factors influencing donation decisions (Smith et al. 2015).

Donors act with individual, corporate, crowdfunding, or multiple donor identities, depending on their motivations. The chosen donation channel (e.g., crowdfunding platforms, nonprofit organizations, corporate initiatives, digital and traditional campaigns) directly influences both the type of donation and the profile of the beneficiaries reached. This process often has a cyclical structure; post-donation experiences, interactions with beneficiaries, and feedback received can strengthen or reshape donor motivations (Bendapudi et al. 1996).

The mutual fit between donation types and beneficiary needs is a key determinant of the process. For example, biological donations are generally geared toward health-related beneficiaries, while knowledge and skills donations are more suitable for education or development-based beneficiaries. Hybrid donations can simultaneously meet the diverse needs of different beneficiary groups. Especially with the rise of digitalization, algorithmic recommendation systems, social media interactions, and platform reliability have become important factors driving donation behavior (Saxton and Wang 2014). Cultural values, social norms, and political factors also contribute to the overall structure of the process by directly influencing donor motivations, channel preferences, and the nature of the bond established with beneficiaries (Wiepking and Bekkers 2012). Thus, donation emerges as a complex social practice shaped by the interaction of psychological, social, digital, and structural elements.

4.4 | Methods (M)

The majority of the studies (79 studies) employed quantitative methods, whereas the rate of studies conducted with qualitative methods was limited to 17 (Figure 4). While this dispersion has enabled the identification of generalizable patterns and tested specific hypotheses, it has also led to a relative neglect of in-depth, contextual, and interpretive insights that qualitative approaches typically provide. The low representation of mixed methods research is particularly noteworthy, considering its potential to bridge the explanatory depth of qualitative inquiry with the generalizability of quantitative analysis. Furthermore, the minimal share of conceptual studies indicates a need for more theoretical integration and development within the field. This imbalance across methodological approaches suggests that existing research may have predominantly focused on measuring and testing predefined relationships, rather than deeply exploring the meanings, dynamics, and underlying processes of donation motivation across varied social and cultural contexts. Upon closely reviewing studies that adopt a quantitative methodology (Table 5), it becomes evident that surveys and questionnaires are prominent as data collection tools. Among the 79 studies analyzed, 27 utilized surveys and 19 employed questionnaires, indicating a significant reliance on survey-based data collection techniques. While some studies sought to engage large audiences via online platforms, others opted for face-to-face methods to gather more detailed information (e.g., Kasri and Indriani 2022). Despite the extensive use of surveys in quantitative research, the reliance on secondary data sources remains limited, with only four studies incorporating them.

In analyzing quantitative data, regression analysis emerges as the most utilized analytic technique, found in 23 studies. Within this framework, a variety of regression techniques were employed. Logistic regression was used to identify factors influencing donation likelihood (e.g., Ryu et al. 2020), hierarchical regression examined interactions among variables at different levels (e.g., Ki and Oh 2018), OLS-based regression modeled linear relationships (e.g., Sherman and Axelrad 2021), and multiple regression assessed the combined effects of various antecedents (e.g., Shehu et al. 2015). Another prevalent analytic technique is Structural Equation Modeling (SEM), utilized in 15 quantitative studies (e.g., da Silva et al. 2020; Hou et al. 2021). Among SEM techniques, Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) was often favored (e.g., Florenthal and Awad 2021; Kasri and Indriani 2022), especially for examining complex causal pathways and latent constructs within donation research. Generally, these variable relationships were analyzed using software like AMOS and SmartPLS (e.g., Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023), while other SEM software packages, such as LISREL and Mplus, were notably absent from the reviewed studies. Additionally, a range of quantitative analytic techniques, including correlation analysis, exploratory and confirmatory factor analysis (EFA, CFA), analysis of variance (ANOVA), and cluster analysis (e.g., Bertacchini et al. 2011; Wallace and Buil 2021; D'Souza et al. 2023). However, it is important to distinguish the analytic purposes of these techniques: correlation analysis and ANOVA are primarily used to test associations or group differences between observed variables; cluster analysis is employed to uncover unobserved groupings or behavioral segments among donors; whereas factor analysis, both

EFA and CFA, is designed to evaluate the structure and validity of psychometric measurement instruments.

This clarification underscores the methodological diversity within the field and the multiple objectives these analytic techniques serve in donation research. Accordingly, the reviewed literature reveals that researchers have a wide array of analytic techniques at their disposal to investigate the motivational, behavioral, and structural dimensions of donation.

When examining qualitative studies, it becomes apparent that the methods for data collection are quite limited. In-depth interviews (11 studies, such as Rombach et al. 2018; Kocaman 2024) emerge as the predominant technique for obtaining a deep understanding of donors' experiences, thoughts, and motivations. This is closely followed by focus group discussions (3 studies, including Sargeant and Shang 2011; Konstantinou and Jones 2022) and the use of secondary data (2 studies, Yoganathan et al. 2021; Rimawati et al. 2025). Only one study combined in-depth interviews with secondary data (Bagheri et al. 2019). The rich qualitative data collected in these studies have typically been analyzed using methods like qualitative content analysis (e.g., Mainardes et al. 2017) and thematic analysis (e.g., Pitts et al. 2020). During these analysis processes, qualitative data analysis software such as Nvivo (e.g., Pitts et al. 2020; Vijaya and Mathur 2022), Atlas.ti (e.g., Mainardes et al. 2017), and CAQDAS (e.g., Rimawati et al. 2025) have been widely employed. In the studies conducted by Kocaman (2024) and Filo et al. (2020), the content and thematic analyses were executed manually. However, clear information regarding the data analysis methods used in 10 of the reviewed qualitative studies remained unavailable (e.g., Yoganathan et al. 2021; Konstantinou and Jones 2022).

Out of the studies reviewed, only five employed mixed methods. In the data collection stage, researchers utilized qualitative techniques like focus group interviews (e.g., Tiltay and Torlak 2020) and individual interviews (e.g., Polonsky et al. 2015; Sabah and Oflazoğlu 2024) to gather rich qualitative data. Some studies complemented these qualitative findings with quantitative data through survey methods (e.g., Curtis et al. 2014; Polonsky et al. 2015). The incorporation of secondary data sources is infrequent in mixed methods research (e.g., Moir and Taffler 2004). For data analysis, content analysis (e.g., Tiltay and Torlak 2020) and thematic analysis (e.g., Sabah and Oflazoğlu 2024) were particularly notable for handling qualitative data. In contrast, factor analysis methods such as Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) (e.g., Sabah and Oflazoğlu 2024) and Explanatory Factor Analysis (EFA) (e.g., Curtis et al. 2014; Tiltay and Torlak 2020) assessed structural validity and explored variable relationships. Various techniques were utilized, including Structural Equation Modeling (e.g., Tiltay and Torlak 2020; Sabah and Oflazoğlu 2024) to illustrate complex relationships, MANOVA (e.g., Moir and Taffler 2004) to investigate group differences, cluster analysis (e.g., Moir and Taffler 2004; Curtis et al. 2014) to detect data patterns, meta-analysis (e.g., Polonsky et al. 2015) for literature synthesis, and regression analysis (e.g., Polonsky et al. 2015) to analyze relationships. Among the studies reviewed, some examined the causes and effects of donation behavior through an experimental lens, focusing on causal relationships. These studies typically aim to analyze the impact of specific factors in a controlled setting, manipulating

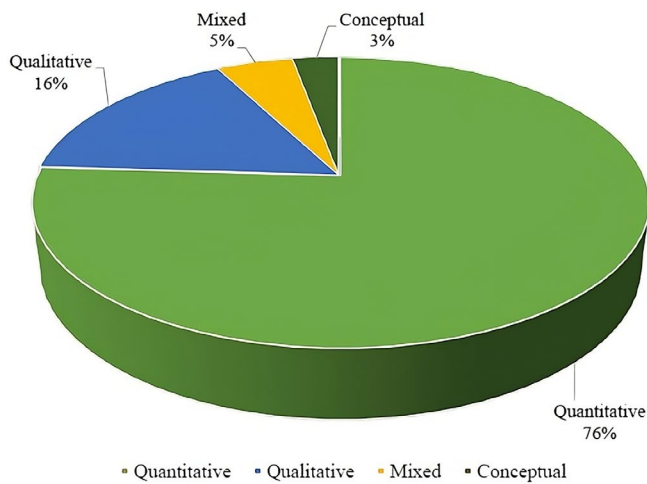


FIGURE 4 | Methodological approaches adopted by studies.

participants' donation intentions or actions using various scenarios or interventions (e.g., Heger et al. 2020; Kim et al. 2022; Song and Ferguson 2023). Additionally, studies that offer theoretical frameworks and conceptual models within the donation motivation literature are also significant. These works seek to integrate existing theories, introduce new conceptual frameworks, or analyze specific phenomena from various theoretical viewpoints, rather than just gathering empirical data (e.g., Grace and Griffin 2006; Aaker and Akutsu 2009). Among the reviewed studies, only one is a systematic literature review by Tangaraja et al. (2015).

It is worth noting that the choice of statistical software across the reviewed studies reflects not only analytical requirements but also broader methodological trends and researcher familiarity. For instance, SmartPLS has become increasingly popular in donation research employing PLS-SEM due to several advantages: (1) it enables structural model testing with small samples, (2) it is robust to non-normal or skewed data distributions, (3) it permits reliable parameter estimation even in the presence of multicollinearity among indicators, and (4) it allows the detection of relationships that might otherwise be obscured by measurement error (Hair et al. 2012; Ringle et al. 2020).

AMOS is another frequently used tool, especially suited for covariance-based SEM when researchers aim to assess model fit indices and confirm theoretical frameworks. Meanwhile, SPSS remains commonly used software for basic statistical procedures such as ANOVA, regression, correlation matrices, and cluster analysis due to its accessible interface and broad usage in social sciences. PROCESS Macro, often used in conjunction with SPSS, facilitates mediation and moderation analysis in a relatively user-friendly way (Hayes 2017), which may explain its frequent adoption in studies exploring psychological mechanisms in donation behavior (e.g., Randle et al. 2016; Chen et al. 2022).

LISREL, one of the earliest SEM programs, was less commonly observed in recent research, perhaps due to its more technical interface. Interestingly, powerful tools like Mplus, known for advanced latent variable modeling, bootstrapping, and multilevel SEM, were uncommon in the reviewed research, suggesting

possible underutilization despite their methodological strength (Muthén and Muthén 2017).

The reviewed literature also featured less traditional software such as ADANCO, Nvivo, Atlas.ti, and G*Power, reflecting an increasing inclination toward methodological plurality. These tools support various needs, from qualitative data coding to sample size calculation and power analysis. Their appearance signals a gradual methodological shift toward more nuanced and multimethod donation research.

Overall, the diversity in statistical software provides insight into how methodological choices align with theoretical frameworks and research questions. Future studies are encouraged to report not only which tools they use but also why, clarifying the analytical benefits and limitations relative to their specific design. This transparency will strengthen replicability and promote critical appraisal of methodological rigor.

5 | Relationship Between Theory-Context-Characteristics-Methods

As the cornerstone of research, theory directly shapes all components within the TCCM framework, context, characteristics, and methods, and thus largely determines not only which variables will be examined but also the context and methodology in which these variables will be addressed (Polit and Beck 2004). For example, Self-Determination Theory explains individuals' intrinsic motivation through basic psychological needs such as autonomy, competence, and relatedness (Deci and Ryan 2008). This theory also directs researchers to focus on how the social and cultural context shapes these needs when examining an individual's voluntary donation behavior. Similarly, social capital theory emphasizes the role of individuals' social networks and relationships in achieving collective benefit (Dubé et al. 2017). Within this theory, research examining individuals' propensity to donate considers the level of trust in donors' social environments, social norms, and the density of social networks as contextual variables (Coleman 1988). In this context, for example, encouragement to donate by a person's family, friends, or religious community may be a determining factor in an individual's adoption of this behavior. In this respect, there is a reciprocal interaction between theory and context. While theory determines how the context is structured, context, in turn, has the potential to challenge, expand, or transform the generalizability of the theory (Paul and Rosado-Serrano 2019).

Similarly, because theory predicts which concepts will be included in the study, how these concepts will be defined and measured, and the possible relationships between them, the characteristics dimension of the research is shaped within the boundaries of the theory. Selecting variables based on a theoretical basis will go beyond simply testing a hypothesis and will clarify how the findings can be integrated into the relevant literature (Sutton and Staw 1995). For example, social exchange theory, used to explain donation behavior, requires focusing on variables such as cost-benefit assessments and perceptions of reciprocity (Cropanzano and Mitchell 2005).

The guiding influence of theory is also reflected in the research method. Researchers using theories based on positivist epistemology generally employ experimental or correlational quantitative methods because they aim to test causality, while interpretive theories, which focus on the production of meaning, prefer qualitative methods (Ari et al. 2009). For example, a study examining the meaning dimension of philanthropic behavior might choose qualitative techniques such as in-depth interviews or thematic analysis to uncover subjective experiences. In this context, the method of the research is not only a pragmatic choice but also a theoretical necessity (Creswell and Poth 2018).

Although the deductive approach is often associated with quantitative research and the inductive approach with qualitative research, this dichotomy is not absolute. In qualitative research, it is possible to collect and analyze data based on an existing theoretical framework; similarly, in quantitative research, patterns can be discovered through data, and new theoretical inferences can be drawn (Munn et al. 2018; Yin 2018). This highlights the flexibility of research approaches and the importance of methodological diversity in understanding complex social phenomena. For example, some qualitative studies adopt a deductive approach when testing the validity of an existing theory in a different context, while inductive approaches, which begin with data, are more common in nature but also find their place in quantitative studies through techniques such as exploratory factor analysis (Guba and Lincoln 1994).

In conclusion, there is a reciprocal and dynamic interaction among the four dimensions of the TCCM framework. The theoretical framework sets the context, and the context, in turn, tests the explanatory power of the theory. Constructing these as complementary elements strengthens the theoretical depth and empirical validity of the research.

5.1 | The Relationship of Theory to Context and Variables in Studies on Donation Behavior

The theoretical basis of research on donation behavior determines which variables and contexts the study will examine. Self-Determination Theory, one of the most widely used theories in the literature, explains how individuals' basic psychological needs, such as autonomy, competence, and relatedness, are reflected in their donation behaviors in the context of donation motivation (Deci and Ryan 2012). Studies conducted in line with this theory have investigated intrinsic and extrinsic motivation variables such as altruism, empathy, personal fulfillment, social recognition, power seeking, and self-image (e.g., Pentecost et al. 2017; Allah Pitchay et al. 2022). The Theory of Planned Behavior explains individuals' donation intentions, and thus their donation behavior, through three primary components: attitude, subjective norm, and perceived behavioral control (Ajzen 1991). In this context, scales measuring the impact of these variables have been widely used in studies on donation behavior (e.g., Zhou et al. 2012; Charsetad 2016). Social Exchange Theory links the donation decision to a cost–benefit assessment; therefore, variables such as “financial commitment, reward expectation, or reciprocity” have been highlighted in the literature (e.g., Bock et al. 2018; Tiltay and Torlak 2020).

Theoretical selection directs the researcher to examine a specific context. Because Self-Determination Theory or Theory is generally individual-centered, most studies have been conducted in Western countries and examined in the context of individualistic cultures. In contrast, theories such as social capital or social identity require focusing on different donation motivations in collectivist societies. The majority of studies in the existing literature have been conducted in the United States, Australia, and the United Kingdom, indicating a limited diversity of contexts.

5.2 | The Relationship of Context With Variables and Methods in Donation Behavior Studies

The context of giving varies not only geographically but also in terms of the components of the giving process. Research has examined the giving process by donor type (individual, corporate, crowdfunding), beneficiaries (healthcare, education, culture and arts, etc.), donation channels (crowdfunding platforms, NGOs, digital channels), and donation types (cash, in-kind, bequests, time, knowledge and skills), detailing how each element interacts with motivations. While digital giving platforms emphasize variables such as trust, transparency, and accessibility in giving (e.g., Hou et al. 2021; Kasri and Indriani 2022), the influence of motivations such as social pressure and status displays can be heightened in in-person donation campaigns. Furthermore, examining giving behavior in Western-centric contexts leaves the literature lacking an understanding of the different motivations that may arise in collective and religious contexts.

As context changes, methodological preferences also change. While online surveys and large samples are prominent in studies conducted on donation behaviors made through digital platforms (e.g., Bin-Nashwan and Al-Daihani 2021; Wallace and Buil 2021), qualitative interviews, focus groups, and ethnographic methods may be more appropriate in contexts such as post-disaster relief campaigns or local community donations.

5.3 | Relationship of Variables With Methods in Donation Behavior Studies

The nature of independent and dependent variables directly impacts data collection and analysis methods (Creswell and Creswell 2018). In donation research, psychological constructs such as motivations, attitudes, and intentions have traditionally been operationalized through standardized scales, which explains the predominance of survey-based methodologies in the field. Psychological motivations, attitudes, and intentions have typically been measured using scales, leading to the proliferation of survey-based data collection and statistical analyses such as regression, ANOVA, or structural equation modeling (e.g., Sherman and Axelrad 2021; Allah Pitchay et al. 2022). Measuring a large portion of the rich range of variables obtained through surveys allowed for the interpretation of the data from a quantitative perspective. In contrast, understanding donor experiences such as trust, sense of belonging, or storytelling requires qualitative or mixed methods. However, the use of such methods appears to be limited in the existing literature.

TABLE 5 | Methodologies of studies.

Study approach	Data collection tool	Analysis technique	Software	Studies
Quantitative	Secondary data	Mediation analysis		Hu et al. 2025
		Regression	PROCESS Macro	Ho 2024
	Questionnaire			Peterson et al. 2021
		Regression (logistic)	STATA	Xie et al. 2024
				Edmondson and Carroll 1999
		ANOVA		Otoo and Amuquandoh 2014
			SPSS	Quee et al. 2022
		Cluster analysis		Balle and Oliveira 2018
		Correlation matrix	SPSS	Awaliah Kasri 2013
		EFA, Regression		Teah et al. 2014
		Mediation analysis, factor analysis	PROCESS Macro	Randle et al. 2016
		Principal component analysis		Triantafyllidis and Kaplanidou 2021
		Regression	SPSS	Nisar et al. 2022
		Regression (OLS)	Stata	Sherman and Axelrad 2021
		Regression (logistic)	PROCESS Macro	Chen et al. 2022
		T-tests	SPSS	Silva Carlos and Rodrigues 2024
		SEM	SmartPLS	Bennett, Vijaygopal, and Kottasz 2023
			LISREL	Charsetad 2016
			SmartPLS	da Silva et al. 2020
			—	Aji 2025
			Smart PLS, SPSS, G* Power	Allah Pitchay et al. 2022
			SPSS	Bargoni et al. 2023
			SmartPLS	Bin-Nashwan and Al-Daihani 2021
	Survey			Fernandes and de Matos 2023
				Florenthal and Awad 2021
			ADANCO	Hou et al. 2021
			AMOS	Johnson and Grimm 2010
			SmartPLS	Kasri and Indriani 2022
			AMOS	Kim et al. 2019
				Martín-Santana et al. 2018
			AMOS	Pentecost et al. 2017
		ANOVA		Bertacchini et al. 2011
				Hsieh and Yucel-Aybat 2018
				Romero-Domínguez et al. 2021
				Kaikati et al. 2017
				Khan et al. 2020

(Continues)

TABLE 5 | (Continued)

Study approach	Data collection tool	Analysis technique	Software	Studies
	Secondary data	CFA	AMOS	Zhou et al. 2012
				M'Sallem 2022
			PROCESS Macro	Mitra et al. 2022
		CFA, ANOVA, cluster analysis	SPSS	Wallace and Buil 2021
		CFA, regression		Zaborek et al. 2025
		Correlation matrix		Gorczyca and Hartman 2017
		EFA	SPSS	D'Souza et al. 2023
		Hierarchical regression analysis		Ki and Oh 2018
		Regression		Müller and Lindenmeier 2022
		Regression (linear)		Song and Ferguson 2023
		Regression (logistic)		Ryu et al. 2020
				Wiepking and Maas 2009
				Wiepking and Bekkers 2012
				Du 2015
				Pentecost and Andrews 2010
	Questionnaire and focus groups	EFA		Opoku 2013
		Descriptive analysis	SPSS	Stötzer et al. 2023
		Correlation matrix		André et al. 2017
				Borello and Muri 2024
				Frimpong et al. 2024
			PROCESS Macro	Gugenishvili et al. 2022
				Minguez and Sese 2023
				Turrini et al. 2020
		Correlation matrix and econometric analysis	STATA	Khodakarami et al. 2015
		Regression		Boudreau et al. 2021
				Kim and Kou 2014
				Lehman and James III 2020
				Zhao et al. 2022
		Regression (bivariate logit)		Shehu et al. 2015
		Regression (logistic)		Konrath et al. 2024
		Regression (PMS)		Gao et al. 2021
		CFA		Beerli-Palacio and Martín-Santana 2009
			PROCESS Macro	Bock et al. 2018
		Correlation matrix		Lee and Kim 2023
				Brady et al. 2002

(Continues)

TABLE 5 | (Continued)

Study approach	Data collection tool	Analysis technique	Software	Studies	
Qualitative	Focus groups	Thematic analysis		Liu and Li 2025	
				Konstantinou and Jones 2022	
				Sargeant and Shang 2011	
	Interviews	Cluster analysis		Cermak et al. 1994	
		Constant comparative method		Bentley 2014	
		Content analysis	Atlas.ti	Mainardes et al. 2017	
		Content analysis, thematic analysis	Manual	Rombach et al. 2018	
				Kocaman 2024	
		Thematic analysis	Manual	Filo et al. 2020	
				Ha-Brookshire and Hodges 2009	
				Jamal et al. 2019	
				Pitts et al. 2020	
	Interviews, secondary data		Nvivo	Vijaya and Mathur 2022	
				Bagheri et al. 2019	
	Online ethnography	Content analysis	CAQDAS	Liu et al. 2020	
	Secondary data	Thematic analysis		Rimawati et al. 2025	
				Yoganathan et al. 2021	
Mixed	Focus groups	EFA, content analysis	AMOS	Tiltay and Torlak 2020	
	Interviews	CFA, thematic analysis	AMOS	Sabah and Oflazoğlu 2024	
	Interviews, survey	EFA, Cluster Analysis	SPSS	Curtis et al. 2014	
		Meta-analysis, regression, factor analysis		Polonsky et al. 2015	
	Secondary data	MANOVA, content analysis, cluster analysis		Moir and Taffler 2004	
Conceptual	Conceptual analysis			Aaker and Akutsu 2009	
				Grace and Griffin 2006	
	Systematic literature review			Tangaraja et al. 2015	

5.4 | The Relationship of Methods With Theory and Context in Donation Behavior Studies

Methodological choices are often aligned with theoretical frameworks. While studies adopting a positivist approach use experimental or correlational quantitative designs to test theoretical models developed to explain donation behavior, the reviewed literature indicates that most research is conducted using quantitative methods, with surveys dominating data collection (Ari et al. [2009](#)). In contrast, interpretive, qualitative approaches may be more appropriate for studies examining donation behavior from a normative or cultural perspective. The DDM model, which summarizes the dynamic interactions between different actors and donation channels within the donation process within the TCCM map, demonstrates that donation behavior is shaped not only by individual motivations but also by the

relationships among donors, beneficiaries, channels, and types of donations. Mixed methods are needed to understand this multilayered structure. The reviewed literature clearly demonstrates how theories shape context, variables, and methods, and how these elements interact with each other. Theories such as Self-Determination Theory and Theory of Planned Behavior have encouraged variables and survey-based quantitative methods to measure both individual motivations and donation intentions, while social exchange and signaling theories have emphasized the social values and status dimensions of donation, leading to the selection of appropriate variables and contexts. The largely Western context and digital channels highlight the lack of cultural diversity and qualitative methodologies in the literature. While defining and mapping variables across a broad range of contexts enhances the richness of the literature, examining these variables largely through the same methods (e.g., surveys,

regression) narrows the scope of research. Therefore, research designs that consider the interactions of each of the TCCM components with others and reflect the dynamic, multidimensional nature of donation behavior are needed.

6 | Agenda for Future Research

Despite the substantial progress in understanding donation behavior, significant theoretical and methodological gaps remain. Future research should prioritize the integration of diverse theories, such as TPB, SDT, and SET, to build comprehensive frameworks that capture both intrinsic and extrinsic motivations underlying donor decisions. Additionally, more attention should be devoted to underexplored contexts, including emerging economies, crisis-driven giving, and technology-mediated donation experiences. Methodologically, future studies can benefit from adopting longitudinal and mixed-method designs to trace changes in donor motivations and loyalty over time, thereby enriching the existing cross-sectional evidence base (Table 6).

Building on these general directions, it is equally essential to consider how the unprecedented disruptions caused by global crises have reshaped donation behaviors and research priorities. In particular, the COVID-19 pandemic has accelerated social, technological, and psychological transformations that call for renewed theoretical and empirical exploration.

COVID-19 has led to profound structural and behavioral transformations across sectors, fundamentally reshaping how individuals think, interact, and contribute to social causes (Alagarsamy et al. 2024; Nayal et al. 2022). The pandemic accelerated the digitalization of donation channels and expanded virtual communities of giving, creating new forms of donor–beneficiary relationships mediated by technology (Purohit et al. 2022; Chopdar et al. 2022). As a result, post-pandemic research should reexamine classical donation theories such as the TPB and SDT through the lens of digital transformation and psychological recovery. Specifically, longitudinal and mixed-method studies could investigate how pandemic-induced emotional states—fear, empathy, anxiety, and solidarity—reshape intrinsic and extrinsic motivations to donate, thereby enriching the theoretical integration suggested in the TCCM framework.

Moreover, as highlighted by Chakraborty and Paul (2023), the pandemic altered consumer–technology interaction patterns and enhanced individuals' reliance on mobile applications for health, community, and philanthropic purposes. Future studies should examine how these newly established digital habits translate into sustained prosocial behavior, including mobile and micro-donation practices. Researchers can explore new constructs such as digital trust, donor technostress, or virtual empathy, using qualitative and quantitative approaches to capture how post-COVID donor journeys differ from pre-pandemic models. Likewise, experimental and neuroscientific designs could measure donors' affective and cognitive responses to digital campaign stimuli (e.g., visual narratives, gamified crowdfunding interfaces), advancing both methodological diversity and emotional theory development within donation behavior research.

Finally, the post-COVID era offers fertile ground for cross-cultural and comparative analyses on the resilience of nonprofit ecosystems and evolving social norms around giving. In line with Nayal et al. (2022), who emphasize organizational adaptability and well-being during crises, future research should investigate how nonprofits cultivate dynamic capabilities to sustain donor engagement amid uncertainty. Comparative studies across regions could assess how differing cultural orientations, economic recoveries, and policy interventions (such as tax incentives or digital transparency regulations) moderate donation intentions and trust. By integrating the pandemic context into donation research, scholars can contribute to developing new theories, scales, and paradigms that more accurately capture post-crisis philanthropic dynamics (Basu et al. 2022), ensuring that future studies remain timely, theoretically robust, and practically relevant in the evolving landscape of social giving.

6.1 | Theory (T)

The existing literature shows that complex behaviors like donations have been explored through a limited number of theoretical frameworks. The prevalent Self-Determination Theory (SDT), Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), and Social Exchange Theory (SET) require deeper examination within the context of donations. For instance, under SDT, research can investigate how donation motivations differ by donation type or donor demographics. TPB can shed light on how subjective norms and perceived behavioral control influence donation intentions and how these intentions are transformed into actual behavior. Likewise, the perceived costs and benefits of donations should encompass more than just monetary aspects, including psychological and social factors. SET could also be broadened to incorporate various forms of exchange, like symbolic exchange, to better understand the dynamics of long-term donor relationships. Similarly, how the core components of SDT, such as autonomy, competence, and relatedness, operate differently in individualistic and collectivistic cultures, or how the TPB may be inadequate in situations of impulsive and spontaneous decision-making, such as on mobile donation platforms where intention formation is limited, should be thoroughly examined. Future research should explicitly address the limitations of dominant theoretical paradigms in explaining donation behavior in culturally diverse or digital contexts.

Future research should focus on creating more holistic approaches by merging theories from various disciplines. For instance, concepts like Affective Events Theory and Appraisal Theory from psychology can help clarify the emotional influences on donation choices. Cognitive Load Theory and Dual Process Decision Making Theory can shed light on decision-making processes. Additionally, integrating theories rooted in Moral Psychology can assist in examining how moral identity and values affect these decisions.

Alongside Natural Philanthropy Theory (NAT) and Social Capital Theory, referenced in several sociology studies, frameworks like Social Identity Theory and Realistic Group Conflict Theory help clarify how individuals' group identities and inter-group dynamics influence donation motivations. Furthermore,

Network Theory serves as an effective tool for analyzing how donation behaviors propagate within donors' social networks.

While traditional economic theories fall short in explaining voluntary donation behavior, Behavioral Economics offers valuable insights with concepts like Loss Aversion, Presentation Style Effects, and Prospect Theory that can inform the creation and impact of donation appeals. Additionally, Game Theory serves as a useful tool to model strategic decision-making in scenarios needing matching donations or collaborative efforts.

It should be acknowledged that a single theory cannot explain donation behavior; therefore, emphasis should be placed on developing comprehensive theoretical models in this area. For instance, integrating intrinsic motivations from Self-Determination Theory (SDT), social benefits from Social Exchange Theory (SET), and intention factors from the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) can lead to more inclusive explanations. Furthermore, multi-level analyses that consider elements like corporate reputation and trust transfer (as per Organizational Adaptation Theory and Trust Transfer Theory) at the organizational level, as well as cultural norms and economic factors (according to Norm Activation Theory and Social Capital Theory) at the societal level, should also be incorporated into the theoretical framework.

To increase theoretical specificity, it is important to explore theories that hold potential for explaining emotional engagement and behavioral change in fundraising campaigns but have limited coverage in the literature. For example, Narrative Transmission Theory may be useful in explaining how stories within fundraising contexts trigger identification and behavioral transformation in individuals. Similarly, approaches such as Identity Fusion Theory or Moral Foundations Theory could be adapted to understand moral intensity and collective alignment in prosocial behavior. A priority area for future research is to empirically test theories that holistically incorporate individual, relational, organizational, and societal dimensions. For example, in the context of digital crowdfunding, testing models that combine moral sentiments from Moral Psychology, trust mechanisms from Trust Transfer Theory, and platform design elements from Cognitive Load Theory could contribute to the development of theoretical frameworks with high explanatory power. Supporting such theory-building processes with comparative and multi-method research conducted across different geographies and donation contexts would enhance both external validity and conceptual robustness. This approach will more accurately reflect the multi-dimensional nature of donation behavior.

6.2 | Context (C)

Recent research emphasizes the importance of contextual dynamics in comprehending this complex phenomenon. While many studies primarily examine individual motivations, donation channels, types of donations, or beneficiary traits, the dynamic interactions among these factors remain underexplored. Notably, both internal and external motivations, preferred channels, and donation experiences can either strengthen or alter these motivations, much like the reciprocal relationships

observed between selected channels and beneficiary characteristics. This interactive process is further enhanced by feedback loops that influence the donor's future decisions, indicating that donation is not merely an individual, one-time choice but a dynamic, relational, and multifaceted process of exchange.

Future studies should prioritize identifying specific contextual moderators that alter the strength or direction of donation motivations, such as institutional credibility, perceived distance to the beneficiary, or digital media saturation. Examining whether motivations such as empathy or warm-glow effects function differently depending on contextual features (e.g., humanitarian crisis vs. stable development campaigns) will add necessary precision to contextual theorizing.

Future research should view donation not merely as an isolated action, but as a complex process influenced by a blend of psychological, social, economic, technological, and institutional factors. Beyond aspects like campaign design or platform familiarity at the micro level, it is vital to thoroughly assess how macro-level elements such as economic trends, socio-cultural values, and global crises impact donation choices. The emergence of new donation environments due to digitalization, such as mobile apps, social media initiatives, and blockchain-enabled transparency systems, provides fresh insights into donor experiences, trust perceptions, and long-term engagement. Examining the user experience and the trust-building strategies associated with these digital tools through comparative and multifaceted methods can significantly contribute to the existing literature. Accordingly, rigorous comparative and multi-method approaches that examine user experience and trust-building strategies in these digital environments can substantially enrich the literature.

Research should further explore the interplay between macro- and micro-level contextual factors by applying multi-level modeling techniques. For example, individual-level predictors (e.g., religiosity, education) may interact with country-level indicators (e.g., philanthropy regulation, GDP, digital access) to shape donation likelihood and preferences. These integrative models will provide more robust insights into context-sensitive donation behavior. Environmental shocks and social changes at the macro level significantly influence donation behavior. Events such as economic downturns, epidemics, or political turmoil can alter not only the amounts donated but also the profile of donors, the areas they prioritize, and their trust in organizations. To understand how these effects evolve over time, longitudinal studies examining the periods before, during, and after a crisis are essential. Likewise, both qualitative and quantitative research that explores how contextual factors, like cultural norms, religious beliefs, generational differences, and socioeconomic status, affect donation behavior will uncover variations in donation culture across different local settings. Such comparative studies should also account for underrepresented geographies and populations, particularly from the Global South, where culturally specific models of giving (e.g., Zakat, Ubuntu, bayanihan) operate through alternative logics and structures. Incorporating these contexts would not only diversify empirical evidence but also challenge the Western-centric bias prevalent in current literature.

A significant yet often neglected aspect of contextual analyses regarding donation behavior is the evolution of donation types

over time. Particularly in donations made through digital platforms and institutions, noticeable differences can arise between the donor's original form of contribution and the final way it is presented. For instance, an individual's cash donation via a specific channel might be transformed by the receiving institution into an in-kind donation, such as food, clothing, or equipment, which is then provided to the beneficiary. These transformations can create discrepancies between the donor's initial intent and the beneficiary's experience, highlighting the importance of transparency in the donation channel and communication method. Future research should develop typologies of donation transformation practices across sectors (e.g., humanitarian vs. educational giving) and assess how transparency mechanisms (e.g., blockchain traceability, third-party certification) mediate donor trust. Thus, this contextual shift in donation types must be considered in relation to the sustainability of the donor's motivations and the beneficiary's perception of the aid received. Future research should closely investigate how these changes impact the donor–beneficiary relationship from both perspectives. Additionally, the dynamics of interaction between donors and recipients are essential to understanding donation behavior, as the process is not merely a transfer of resources but also an interaction enriched with social, symbolic, and emotional significance. Feedback mechanisms, such as beneficiaries sending thank-you notes, sharing visuals, or providing impact reports, are crucial in affirming and appreciating donor contributions. These interactions not only enhance the emotional satisfaction of donors but may also strengthen long-term commitment and intentions to donate again. Factors like the visibility of the beneficiary, narrative styles, and the privacy of the relationship with donors significantly influence this process.

Scholars should empirically examine how different feedback mechanisms (e.g., personalized vs. mass communication, symbolic vs. informational feedback) influence donors' emotional reactions and re-donation likelihood. Therefore, further research should delve into how interactions between donors and beneficiaries are shaped in specific contexts, the tools that facilitate these interactions, and how they ultimately affect donation behavior using both qualitative and quantitative approaches.

Ultimately, further in-depth research is essential regarding corporate giving and the perception of trust. There is a need to move beyond generic corporate social responsibility models and investigate how organizational identity, brand-cause fit, and industry-specific norms interact with contextual pressures. Sector-specific comparative studies (e.g., finance vs. healthcare) can reveal how corporate social responsibility strategies adapt under regulatory or reputational stress. What contextual factors influence the shaping of companies' social responsibility strategies? How do stakeholder pressures, sectoral norms, or economic incentives affect these choices? Studies aimed at answering these questions can illuminate the context behind corporate giving decisions. Additionally, it is crucial to investigate how perceptions of trust and transparency are constructed in various contexts and which communication strategies prove most effective, utilizing experimental and longitudinal research methods. Furthermore, cross-cultural studies examining how donor expectations around transparency and accountability differ by national giving cultures can guide the development of adaptive communication strategies. These multi-level

contextual analyses will enhance theoretical understanding of giving behavior and aid in the creation of more effective giving strategies in practice.

6.3 | Characteristics (C)

Research exploring the intricate elements influencing donation behavior often emphasizes motivational factors and individual demographic traits as antecedents. In contrast, institutional and project-related elements, including communication strategies and message/platform-specific aspects, alongside factors linked to the donor–institution relationship, remain relatively underexplored in scholarly works.

Future studies should systematically classify and empirically test institutional characteristics such as brand reputation, transparency cues, governance practices, and relational cues (e.g., responsiveness, personalization) to understand how they shape donor attitudes and behavior across different campaign settings.

While previous studies primarily concentrate on donation intentions and behaviors as dependent variables, there is a need to investigate a broader array of outcomes. These include factors like motivation for donation, the total donation amount, campaign effectiveness, psychological impacts on individuals, and outcomes for organizations.

There is also a research gap concerning the negative or unintended consequences of donation campaigns, such as donor fatigue, moral licensing, or over-reliance on emotional appeals. Integrating these underexamined outcomes would offer a more balanced and ethically sensitive framework for evaluating donation behavior.

Furthermore, it is critical to highlight that donation behavior is influenced not only by individual factors but also by wider macro-environmental conditions. Elements such as economic fluctuations, political unrest, socio-cultural shifts, technological advancements, environmental challenges, and global crises can significantly impact both an individual's capacity and motivation to donate, as well as their trust in institutions. These macro factors may further amplify or diminish the impact of micro-level variables.

To account for this complexity, scholars should develop interactional models that examine how donor traits (e.g., risk aversion, religiosity, digital literacy) moderate the effects of contextual disruptions. For instance, how does political instability alter the perceived legitimacy of NGOs among different demographic groups?

Future research should focus on assessing both the independent and interactive influences of micro (e.g., communication styles, platform features, links to the institution) and macro (e.g., economic uncertainty, social trust, environmental concerns) variables on donation behaviors. In doing so, scholars should consider adopting typologies of donor behavior, such as one-time versus recurring donors, transactional versus relational donors, or reactive versus proactive givers, to examine how different variable constellations predict distinct

behavioral outcomes. Instead of solely focusing on initial donations or intent, research should encompass more comprehensive measures like repeat donations, total donation amounts, campaign participation, and the tangible impact of donations. Moreover, research must advance measurement practices beyond simplistic Likert scales by employing behavioral tracking (e.g., click-through rates, real-time giving data), experimental simulations, or psychophysiological tools (e.g., eye-tracking, heart rate variability) to more accurately capture donor responses and engagement. In this light, developing integrated models that elucidate the processes affecting donation behavior at various levels is essential. Such models should clearly distinguish between proximal predictors (e.g., message framing, platform usability) and distal influences (e.g., ideology, social norms), while also accounting for mediating mechanisms such as emotional arousal, perceived control, or social identification. Lastly, there should be a broader application of longitudinal designs and multilevel analysis methods to better understand the evolving nature of donation behavior and track changes over time. Such methodologies will not only enhance theoretical insights into donation behavior but also aid in creating more effective fundraising strategies for NPOs. To this end, future work should prioritize panel data collection, diary methods, and multi-wave field experiments to capture temporal shifts in donor motivation, trust, and loyalty. This is especially relevant in times of uncertainty or digital transformation, where traditional behavioral assumptions may no longer hold.

6.4 | Methods (M)

While the methodological approaches in the reviewed literature have significantly enhanced understanding of donation behavior, they primarily rely on survey-based and quantitative methods, which introduce certain limitations. Notably, these include challenges in clearly demonstrating causal relationships between variables and tracking changes in donation processes over time. Relying solely on quantitative methods may not adequately capture the personal experiences of donors, the psychological and social factors influencing their decision-making, and their specific contexts. Moreover, the scarcity of experimental and longitudinal research hinders the assessment of the effectiveness of various interventions and our ability to track shifts in donor behavior. Future research should clearly differentiate between explanatory and exploratory goals when selecting methods and design choices. Scholars aiming to test theoretically grounded hypotheses, such as the effects of message framing or trust signals, should prioritize experimental or quasi-experimental designs to establish causality, whereas those investigating emergent behaviors or context-dependent meanings may benefit more from qualitative or mixed methods.

To enhance the understanding of donation behavior, it is essential to embrace methodological diversity. Promoting a broader application of experimental and quasi-experimental designs can better clarify causal relationships. Utilizing field experiments, online experimental platforms, or natural experimental settings allows for a more detailed examination of how specific communication strategies, incentive structures, and contextual elements affect donation decisions. Particular attention should be paid to pre-registered and pre-tested experimental protocols,

which can strengthen the internal validity and replicability of findings, especially in areas prone to social desirability bias such as charitable giving. Additionally, greater emphasis on longitudinal research is crucial for analyzing the evolution of the donor experience over time, the relational dynamics involved, and the influence of broad environmental changes. Such studies that monitor the donation behaviors of the same individuals over extended periods can uncover insights like continuity, turning points, and behavioral shifts. Panel designs that capture fluctuations in donor trust, emotional engagement, and responsiveness to appeals before, during, and after significant events (e.g., humanitarian crises, scandals) will be especially informative. These designs also allow for testing retention strategies and the long-term impact of donor engagement efforts.

Mixed methods studies, blending the extensive reach of quantitative data with the profound insights from qualitative data, hold significant potential for a comprehensive understanding of the complex nature of donation behavior. Particularly, methods like explanatory or exploratory sequential designs can effectively uncover the meanings behind numerical associations. To further improve the analytical depth of mixed methods research, future studies should apply formal integration techniques, such as joint displays, meta-inferences, or design meta-matrices, to explicitly connect findings across strands rather than treating them as parallel outputs. The growing availability of big data sources, including digital donation platforms and operational data from civil society organizations, facilitates the adoption of more sophisticated quantitative analysis techniques. In this regard, approaches such as time series analysis, panel data models, and social network analysis, which are especially useful for exploring donor relationships and network effects, can greatly enhance the understanding of donation behavior across various dimensions. Furthermore, the integration of machine learning methods (e.g., clustering, classification trees, and natural language processing) into donation research can offer scalable solutions for pattern recognition, donor segmentation, and message optimization across massive datasets.

It is essential to broaden the methodological spectrum of qualitative research; rich descriptions of donors' motivations, experiences, and the meanings they assign to their donations can be achieved through phenomenological studies, narrative analyses, and in-depth case studies. Ethnographic immersion in giving environments, such as community-based fundraising events or digital giving platforms, can uncover the implicit norms and symbolic dimensions of donation interactions often missed in other designs.

Finally, careful design of sampling strategies is crucial, ensuring representativeness in data collection. Innovative sources like digital trace data and biometric data should complement systematic methods such as random or stratified sampling. Sampling strategies must also prioritize diversity in donor typologies (e.g., age, income, giving frequency, ideology) and geographies, especially underrepresented contexts in the Global South, to avoid overgeneralizing from narrow or convenience-based samples. By adhering to essential principles like transparency, repeatability, and scientific validity in implementing these methodological recommendations, the reliability and sustainability of knowledge in the field of donation behavior will be bolstered.

TABLE 6 | Agenda for future research using the TCCM framework.

Research questions	Avenues for future research
<i>Theory (T)</i>	
How can the currently widely used SDT, TPB, and SET be integrated to explain donation behavior?	– Develop holistic models that combine elements of SDT, TPB, and SET to simultaneously examine the effects of intrinsic and extrinsic motivations on donation decisions. – Create a new “Donation Decision Model” that brings together intrinsic motivations from SDT, intention and behavioral control from TPB, and social benefits from SET.
How can the emotional antecedents of donation decisions (e.g., empathy, guilt, pride) be explained?	– Adapt emotional approaches from the discipline of psychology, such as Appraisal Theory or Affective Events Theory, to the donation process to model motivations based on empathy or guilt. – Use Dual-Process Theory, which considers emotional and cognitive processes together. – Investigate the interaction between emotional triggers (empathy) and rational evaluations (cost–benefit perception).
How can theories that are relatively less used in relevant literature (e.g., Norm Activation Theory, Realistic Group Conflict Theory) be studied from different perspectives?	– Adapt Norm Activation Theory to examine individuals’ perceptions of “social responsibility” and behavioral pressures. – Compare levels of normative pressure across cultural contexts. – Use Realistic Group Conflict Theory. – Test which donors’ attitudes based on their group identities (ethnic, religious, regional) drive campaign types.
How can theories that are relatively less used in relevant literature be studied in different contexts (e.g., disaster grants, international aid)?	– Examine the effects of theories such as Norm Activation and Social Capital Theory in comparative studies by testing them in different geographical regions (Africa, Southeast Asia, Latin America) and depending on the cultural/economic context. – Conduct validity analyses of Adaptation Theory or Animosity Theory by comparing voluntary donation decisions in times of crisis (e.g., pandemic, earthquake) with the global context.
<i>Context (C)</i>	
How do macro environmental shocks (economic crisis, pandemic, natural disaster) affect donation trends and trust?	– Use longitudinal datasets to examine the pre-crisis, mid-crisis, and post-crisis periods comparatively. – Examine changes in donation amounts, channel preferences, and beneficiary areas. – Conduct comparative studies to assess how regional and demographic differences moderate this effect.
How is the giving experience reshaped in the context of digitalization and new technologies?	– Examine in depth the trust, user experience, and loyalty mechanisms created by digital channels, such as crowdfunding, mobile donation applications, and blockchain-based transparency systems, using mixed-method research. – Empirically compare the effects of A/B tests, conversion rates, and user interface improvements on donor behavior on different digital platforms.
How do socio-cultural norms, religious values, and generational identities shape donation behavior?	– Qualitatively examine the donation rituals and expectations of different ethnic/religious communities through ethnographic and focus group studies. – Quantitatively model the impact of digital tool usage habits across generations (Generation Y, Z, X) on giving motivation through longitudinal surveys.
What contextual conditions (sectoral norms, tax incentives, stakeholder pressures) do corporate giving and business participation depend on?	– Conduct mixed-methods design studies to examine how corporate donors perceive stakeholder pressure and industry norms as moderator variables. – Measure the impact of the presence/intensity of tax incentives on corporate giving budgets and preferred campaign areas with panel data analyses.

(Continues)

TABLE 6 | (Continued)

Research questions	Avenues for future research
<i>Characteristics (C)</i>	
How does the transformation of donation types affect donor perception and beneficiary experience?	– Document how a donation is converted from monetary to in-kind donation by the channel through case studies and process tracing research, and analyze donor satisfaction and trust perception through surveys and in-depth interviews. – Explore how the beneficiary experienced this transformed in-kind donation through impact stories and photo/visual analysis.
How does the interaction between donor and beneficiary (feedback, thank you, story sharing) reflect on donor loyalty?	– Use qualitative case studies to reveal how different NPOs' thank-you mechanisms (face-to-face visits, digital certificates, video messages) affect donor emotional satisfaction. – Use e-surveys and experimental designs to quantitatively assess the impact of feedback frequency and format (text, visual, or video) on repeat donation intention.
What are the transformative factors in the donor's transition from initial donation experience to repeat donation behavior?	– Identify donor profiles from the moment of their first donation through longitudinal analyses to identify motivational turning points in the transition to repeat donation. – Identify “transformation triggers” (emotional connection, campaign urgency, and macro environmental changes) through both narrow survey data and in-depth interviews using a mixed-methods approach.
<i>Methods (M)</i>	
How to get the dynamics of the donor journey and the impacts of macroenvironmental changes?	– In longitudinal (panel or cohort) studies, models how variables such as frequency, amount, and channel preference evolve by following the same group of donors over time. – Apply interrupted time series analysis to detect breaks in donor behavior during periods encompassing macro environmental shocks (e.g., economic crisis, natural disaster).
What mixed-methods design should be chosen to understand the complexity of donation behavior?	– With the explanatory sequential model, first identify general trends based on quantitative surveys and then collect confirmatory qualitative data by conducting in-depth interviews with selected donors. – With the exploratory sequential model, first uncover sub-themes with focus groups/ethnography and apply the scales developed in the second stage to large-sample surveys to generalize.
How can big-data analytics be integrated into donation research?	– Examine long-term trends in transaction data collected from digital platforms, including crowdfunding, mobile donation applications, NPOs, and CRM systems, using time series analysis and panel data models. – Use social network analysis to reveal the relationship between donors' online interaction networks (including friendship and sharing relationships) and the amount and frequency of their donations.
What approaches to qualitative research provide the richest exposure to donor experiences?	– In phenomenological studies, analyze in depth the meanings donors attribute to their “first donation experience.” – In narrative analysis, examine the organization of donor stories and the metaphors they use to reveal emotional and social themes. – Identify practical insights by simultaneously documenting donor and beneficiary interactions in a specific region or campaign context with in-depth case studies.
How can sampling strategies and data collection processes be improved?	– Examine demographic and geographic diversity by ensuring population representation using random and stratified sampling methods. – Enrich datasets by integrating secondary data sources (e.g., government social assistance records, NPOs operational databases) with digital trace data (social media interactions, mobile donation records). – Test biometric or behavioral data collection methods (e.g., eye tracking, affective measurements) in pilot studies to analyze donor responses and motivations with a multidisciplinary approach.

7 | Theoretical Implications

As Nicholson et al. (2018) highlight, academic research enriches the knowledge base through consolidation, incremental contributions, and uncovering insights. In this regard, the current study systematically synthesizes and clarifies the expanding literature on the subject using the TCCM framework, thereby making a valuable consolidative contribution. Over the past two decades, several literature reviews, both narrative and systematic, have examined the determinants of donation behavior. For instance, Alias and Ismail (2015) explored donation behavior among healthcare volunteers, highlighting contextual determinants such as altruism, organizational identification, and moral obligation. While valuable, the sector-specific focus of their review limits its applicability to broader giving contexts. Bekkers and Wiepking (2011) synthesized empirical studies, primarily from Western contexts, to identify eight mechanisms influencing charitable giving (e.g., awareness of need, costs and benefits, altruism, reputation, psychological benefits). Their narrative approach provided a foundational conceptual framework but lacked an integrated analysis of theoretical, contextual, and methodological dimensions. Chapman et al. (2021) conducted a systematic review and meta-analysis focused specifically on the role of trust in charitable giving. They provided compelling evidence that trust exerts both direct and moderating effects on donor behavior, yet their thematic scope excluded other psychological, social, and contextual determinants. Kumar and Chakrabarti (2023) produced a systematic review covering studies from 1990 to 2020, categorizing findings into donor characteristics, fundraising strategies, and giving contexts. While comprehensive, their review did not explicitly integrate theoretical frameworks and offered limited methodological mapping. Lammam and Gabler (2012) synthesized macro- and micro-level determinants from economic and policy perspectives in a narrative review, but largely omitted insights from psychology and sociology. Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007a, 2007b) similarly used a narrative approach to examine donor loyalty and commitment, offering deep insights into retention behavior but without linking findings to a wider array of determinants. Wiepking and Bekkers (2012) reviewed predictors of donation behavior across socio-demographic and psychological factors, again relying on a narrative synthesis and providing minimal methodological reflection. In addition to these, a typical pattern across much of this literature is the predominance of narrative reviews, which, while rich in descriptive insights, often lack the systematic procedures needed to ensure transparency, replicability, and comprehensiveness (Snyder 2019). Narrative reviews are more prone to selection bias, and they frequently underreport search strategies, inclusion criteria, and analytical procedures, making it difficult for subsequent researchers to replicate findings or assess the completeness of the evidence base. By contrast, SLRs follow a transparent, predefined protocol for identifying, selecting, and analyzing studies, thereby reducing bias, improving reproducibility, and enabling more structured synthesis across theoretical, contextual, and methodological dimensions (Tranfield et al. 2003). Another recurring limitation of previous reviews, whether narrative or systematic, is the absence of a structured, forward-looking research agenda. While some reviews note gaps in the literature, they often do so in an ad hoc manner, without organizing these gaps systematically or linking them explicitly to theoretical, contextual, and methodological

considerations. The present study addresses these shortcomings by applying the TCCM framework to map the literature on the key drivers of donation behavior in a multi-dimensional way. This approach allows for theoretical integration by identifying and categorizing the lenses used to explain donation behavior; contextual breadth by including studies from diverse cultural, socio-economic, and situational settings; methodological mapping by assessing trends in research design, data collection, and analysis techniques; and structured agenda-setting by systematically identifying research gaps and formulating a targeted future research agenda that bridges theoretical, contextual, and methodological domains.

To add the incremental value, the current study pinpoints underexplored areas in the literature and proposes practical directions for future research across theoretical, contextual, and methodological dimensions. The study emphasizes previously neglected elements in the literature and presents innovative approaches to reevaluate established theoretical frameworks. It plays a role in shaping the future research agenda by introducing fresh perspectives on the application of established theories. Additionally, the theoretical framework used in this study highlights the contributions from various theoretical perspectives in understanding donation behavior. For example, according to Signaling Theory (Spence 2002), individuals express credibility and worth to their social environment through their donations. This indicates that donation behavior is not merely altruistic but also strategic. Such an approach allows donations to be viewed as a means of communication, thereby offering a significant contribution to the mostly one-dimensional views found in the literature. Likewise, the integration of Self-Determination Theory, Norm Activation Theory, and the Theory of Planned Behavior facilitates the creation of a comprehensive view that encompasses intrinsic and extrinsic motivations, normative influences, and cognitive planning. This theoretical breadth delivers a unique and holistic insight into the field by systematically outlining how the study subject is understood across various disciplines. Another significant theoretical contribution of this review is its organized classification of research trends from the past 30 years, offering a long-term perspective on the field's intellectual evolution. The results indicate that a variety of theories, particularly from psychology, sociology, and economics, are employed, highlighting the necessity for interdisciplinary strategies to gain a deeper understanding of the intricate motivations that drive donation behavior.

Also, the study systematically categorizes different variable types that have been inconsistently addressed in current literature, clarifying the complex structures that influence donation behavior. It identifies individual, demographic, psychological, and environmental factors that affect motivations for donating, while also examining their influences on outcomes like donation intention, behavior, and amounts donated. The research evaluates the socio-cultural context's impact through control variables, analyzes psychological mechanisms involved in the donation process (such as perceived benefits, trust, and commitment) with mediating variables, and uncovers the varying effects of context (including donation type and campaign form) using moderating variables. In this context, the study elucidates both the individual impact of variables influencing donation behavior and their interactions, as well as the underlying mechanisms.

Furthermore, the analysis reveals that research on the relevant subject centers on several key aspects, including donor motivations, recipient traits, donation channels, and types. This variety underscores the significance of donation behavior as a multidimensional value exchange process in marketing. Nevertheless, the scarcity of studies that combine these elements into a unified framework undermines the consistency and generalizability of the results, clearly showing the necessity for more thorough and integrative research.

The review also reveals that current research primarily focuses on countries such as the United States, Australia, and the United Kingdom. This geographical imbalance highlights the need to expand the scope of literature to encompass underrepresented areas, as emphasized in the proposed future research agenda. Furthermore, methodologically, the discipline is primarily defined by quantitative methods. The limited use of qualitative and mixed methods presents a significant opportunity to achieve a more comprehensive and nuanced understanding of donation behavior. Finally, future research could benefit from a more organized mapping of the field, utilizing empirical approaches and systematic review methods. These strategies would enhance conceptual clarity and offer stronger practical guidance. This review highlights research gaps using the TCCM framework and outlines a structured direction for developing the literature on donation motivations.

8 | Managerial Implications

Understanding the complex and interrelated motivations behind donation behavior provides a critical foundation for designing more effective, targeted, and sustainable fundraising strategies. For nonprofit managers and fundraising professionals, this means moving beyond generalized appeals and adopting a motivation-driven segmentation approach. For instance, individual donors driven by intrinsic motivations such as empathy, moral duty, or personal meaning may respond more positively to emotionally compelling narratives. A healthcare nonprofit, for example, could highlight the personal stories of patients whose lives were saved by organ donations or critical care funding. This appeals to the donor's internal desire to relieve suffering and seek emotional fulfillment through altruistic action. Conversely, donors with extrinsic motivations, such as social recognition or reputational gains, may be more responsive to visible acknowledgment. For example, universities seeking corporate donations for scholarship programs or infrastructure could offer naming rights, media exposure, or inclusion in prestigious donor recognition events. A technology company, for instance, might be more inclined to support STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics) education initiatives if the donation is publicly associated with its brand and aligns with its CSR goals. Channel selection must also align with donor motivation. Donors who value transparency, speed, and direct impact, typically those driven by empathy or a desire for personal meaning, may prefer digital platforms such as GoFundMe or JustGiving, which offer real-time updates and measurable outcomes. In contrast, status-seeking or corporate donors might gravitate toward high-profile gala events, CSR initiatives, or structured partnerships with established nonprofits, where visibility and stakeholder engagement are emphasized. NPOs should develop donor personas based on psychographic

attributes and motivational profiles rather than relying solely on demographics. For example, an environmental NGO could simultaneously run two campaigns: one leveraging warm-glow giving through personal testimonials from reforestation beneficiaries for individual donors, and another focusing on green branding benefits for businesses that sponsor climate mitigation projects. In addition, policymakers play a pivotal role in shaping the broader environment in which donation behaviors occur. Tax incentives and regulatory frameworks can either reinforce or hinder certain types of giving. For example, policymakers could design progressive tax benefits that reward not only large monetary donations but also in-kind, time, or knowledge-based contributions, encouraging a wider range of citizens to participate in philanthropic activity. Similarly, creating transparent certification systems for nonprofit organizations could increase public trust, appealing to extrinsically motivated donors concerned with legitimacy and visibility. Moreover, policymakers may consider funding initiatives that support digital infrastructure for local or grassroots nonprofits, ensuring they can compete effectively in the increasingly digital and competitive fundraising landscape. For instance, small community health centers could benefit from government-supported platforms that facilitate crowdfunding or donor engagement through mobile apps, tools typically dominated by larger NGOs with greater resources. Finally, public campaigns promoting prosocial norms, such as national giving days, school-based philanthropy education, or civic recognition programs for exemplary donors, can reinforce both intrinsic values and socially desirable behaviors, fostering a culture of giving that transcends socioeconomic status. By recognizing that donation behavior is a dynamic interplay of psychological, social, and structural forces, practitioners and policymakers can design more nuanced strategies and interventions that increase donations and ensure they are sustainable, inclusive, and impactful. This integrated approach acknowledges the full spectrum of motivations and channels at play, ultimately contributing to a more robust and equitable philanthropic ecosystem.

9 | Limitations

As with all systematic literature reviews, this study has certain limitations that warrant consideration. First, the review exclusively sourced articles from the Web of Science (WoS) database. While WoS encompasses many leading journals and offers a strong foundation for academic synthesis, it may not capture all relevant studies, particularly those published in databases with broader or region-specific coverage. To enhance the comprehensiveness and diversity of future reviews, researchers are encouraged to incorporate additional databases such as Scopus, ScienceDirect, EBSCO, and JSTOR, ensuring careful deduplication to avoid redundancy. These platforms may yield further relevant studies not indexed or only partially covered by WoS, thereby enriching the review's scope and depth. Second, despite employing a rigorous keyword-driven search strategy, it is possible that some pertinent studies were omitted due to limitations in how keywords, titles, or abstracts were framed. Future research could benefit from iterative keyword testing and broader semantic variations to improve retrieval sensitivity. Third, due to time constraints, this review did not include an expert panel or peer validation step during the screening process. Incorporating expert reviews in future work could enhance the reliability and methodological robustness of study selection

and thematic categorization. Lastly, the analysis was based on 116 peer-reviewed journal articles, primarily situated within the domains of marketing, psychology, nonprofit management, and consumer behavior. While this focus allowed for in-depth insights into dominant disciplinary perspectives, it may have constrained the interdisciplinarity of the findings. Future studies could adopt a more integrative approach by engaging scholars across diverse academic fields, thereby fostering richer, more nuanced discussions that bridge theoretical and practical insights across sectors.

10 | Conclusion

This study underscores the complexity and interdisciplinary breadth of donation motivation, revealing it as a multifaceted phenomenon shaped by an intricate interplay of internal psychological drivers, external social influences, and contextual dynamics. By employing a systematic literature review (SLR) grounded in the TCCM (Theory–Context–Characteristics–Methods) framework, the study consolidates fragmented research across diverse disciplines, theoretical paradigms, and methodological approaches. The review highlights key theoretical underpinnings, including self-determination theory, the theory of planned behavior, and signaling theory, while also identifying significant gaps in conceptual coherence and integration. Contextually, the findings highlight the increasing significance of digital transformation and global crises in shaping donor behavior, particularly among younger, tech-savvy demographics. The categorization of donor motivations into intrinsic and extrinsic dimensions, ranging from empathy and moral obligation to social recognition and reputational gain, demonstrates the nuanced and often overlapping nature of these drivers. Methodologically, the review points to a strong reliance on quantitative research, signaling a need for more longitudinal, qualitative, and mixed-methods studies that can capture the evolving and context-sensitive dimensions of donation. Ultimately, this synthesis provides a robust foundation for future research agendas, calling for more integrative theoretical models, diverse methodological designs, and culturally contextualized studies. It also offers valuable insights for practitioners and policymakers seeking to design more effective, targeted, and ethically informed donor engagement strategies. As the philanthropic landscape continues to evolve, driven by technological innovation, social change, and global interconnectedness, understanding the motivations behind donation behavior becomes ever more critical to sustaining and enhancing collective action for the public good.

Funding

The authors have nothing to report.

Ethics Statement

We ensure that this research has been conducted following ethical principles.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Data sharing not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

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